A Doctoral Thesis

Mutually Assured Delivery

Chiral Inheritance, the Dead Hand, and the Metaxic Medium in the Ludic Corpus of Hideo Kojima



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Contents

Abstract 4

Prefatory Note 6

Introduction 9
The Stick, the Rope, and the Hand Between

I The Stick 15
Deterrence, Genes, and the Fathers

1 Outer Heaven 16
The Soldier's Heterotopia and the Grammar of Deterrence

2 The Selfish Clone 23
Genes, Twins, and the Myth of the Inferior Brother

3 The Joy and the Sorrow 30
Loyalty, Sacrifice, and the Ouroboros

II The Meme 39
Simulation, Context, and Control

4 Selection for Societal Sanity 40
The Menardian Sequel and the Prophecy of Context

5 The Dead Hand 47
Mortmain, the War Economy, and the Society of Control

III The Phantom 55
Language, Revenge, and Mourning

6 Parasitic Tongues 56
Language as Weapon, Homeland, and Symbiont

7 The Man Who Sold the World 61
Phantom Limbs, Revenge, and the Legend as Prosthesis

8 The Loop 67
P.T., Repetition Compulsion, and the Hauntological Artifact

IV The Strand 71
Connection, Custody, Extinction

9 The Stick and the Rope 72
The Ontology of Connection in Death Stranding

10 Should We Have Connected? 81
Death Stranding 2 and the Autoimmunity of the Network

V Synthesis 89
Mutually Assured Delivery

11 Incongruent Counterparts 90
A Theory of Chiral Inheritance

12 From Mutually Assured Destruction to Mutually Assured Delivery 96

13 The Metaxic Medium 101
Toward a Kojimean Ludology

Conclusion 104
Keeping the Line Open

Bibliography 107

Keywords 113

Abstract

This thesis advances a unified philosophical reading of the ludic corpus written, directed, or conceived by Hideo Kojima (b. 1963), from *Metal Gear* (1987) to *Death Stranding 2: On the Beach* (2025). Against the critical commonplace that partitions the oeuvre into a militarist phase of the stick (the *Metal Gear* saga) and a reparative phase of the rope (the *Death Stranding* diptych), it contends that the corpus constitutes a single, self-transforming myth-system whose master-figure is the line: the serpent that coils (Snake), the serpent that devours itself (the ouroboros), and the cord that extends toward an other (the Strand). Reconstructing the genealogy of Kojima's thematics – Dawkins's gene and meme, Abe Kōbō's stick and rope, Huizinga's *Homo ludens* and Morin's *Homo demens*, the deterrence theory of Brodie, Kahn, and Schelling, the linguistic relativity that descends from Humboldt through Sapir and Whorf, Egyptian soul-doctrine and the Japanese underworld of Yomi – and placing it in sustained comparison with Melville, Borges, Dick, Le Guin, Ishiguro, Stephenson, Delany, Lem, and a mythic archive running from Hesiod and Genesis to the *Kojiki*, the study proposes three interlocking constructs.

The first is *chiral inheritance*. Kojima models every regime of transmission – genetic, memetic, scenic, sensory, linguistic, infrastructural – on the structure Kant called the incongruent counterpart and Kelvin named chirality: the heir as the mirror-image of the ancestor, identical in content yet non-superposable in orientation. Catastrophe issues from every attempt to force coincidence (the clone, the simulation, the phantom double, the governance of the living by the dead); ethical life issues from the acceptance of handedness. The second is *the Dead Hand*. Across nuclear registers (the Soviet Perimeter system and the automated retaliation of *Peace Walker*), juridical registers (mortmain), political registers (the Patriots' artificial intelligences, named for the four faces of Mount Rushmore in defiance of Jefferson's dictum that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living), and metaphysical registers (the handprints of *Death Stranding*'s Beached Things), Kojima isolates a single antagonist – the dominion of the dead over the living – and opposes to it the living, carrying hand. The third is *Mutually Assured Delivery*: a ludic counter-doctrine to Mutually Assured Destruction, legible in the contrast between *The Phantom Pain*'s networked deterrence economy and *Death Stranding*'s asynchronous gift economy, which preserves deterrence's insight that interdependence pacifies while inverting its valence from shared threat to shared burden. *Death Stranding 2*'s interrogation of its own network then exposes the doctrine's autoimmune vulnerability and yields a

mature katechontic ethic: the porter as a restrainer from below, who defers rather than abolishes the end.

These constructs converge in a theory of the videogame as a *metaxic medium*, synthesizing Plato's daimonic *metaxy*, Simone Weil's figure of the wall that at once separates and connects two prisoners, and Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics of *aidagara* (betweenness): a medium whose player–avatar relation is itself chiral, and whose highest vocation in Kojima's hands is the custody of the two beings who dwell between – the unborn and the dead. The thesis concludes that Kojima is misdescribed as a maker of "cinematic" games and is better understood as the author of a sustained ludic philosophy of transmission under conditions of rupture, whose decisive contribution is to reconceive play itself as the carrying of what cannot be carried alone.

Prefatory Note

Corpus, Authorship, and Conventions

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the works Kojima wrote, directed, or conceived as lead creator: *Metal Gear* (1987); *Snatcher* (1988); *Metal Gear 2: Solid Snake* (1990); *Policenauts* (1994); *Metal Gear Solid* (1998); *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (2001); *Boktai: The Sun Is in Your Hand* (2003); *Metal Gear Solid 3: Snake Eater* (2004); *Metal Gear Solid 4: Guns of the Patriots* (2008); *Metal Gear Solid: Peace Walker* (2010); *Metal Gear Solid V: Ground Zeroes* (2014); *P.T.* (2014); *Metal Gear Solid V: The Phantom Pain* (2015); *Death Stranding* (2019; Director's Cut 2021); and *Death Stranding 2: On the Beach* (2025). *Zone of the Enders* (2001), which Kojima produced, is cited where its child-pilot thematics bear on the argument. The secondary authorial corpus consists of Kojima's essay collection *The Creative Gene* (English edition 2021), his interviews, and the paratexts through which his studio presents itself, above all the emblem "Ludens," whose name descends from Huizinga.



Figure 0.1 *The corpus as a single line, 1987–2025. Filled knots mark works Kojima directed; open knots, works he produced or designed. The line breaks once, in 2015.*

Open works. Two projects stand at the horizon of the corpus as of the date of this thesis. *OD*, a horror anthology developed with Xbox Game Studios and co-written with Jordan Peele, remains in production without a release date. *Physint*, an action-espionage project, lost the publishing support of PlayStation Studios in June 2026 and was taken up by Xbox in September 2026; Kojima has projected its release beyond 2030 (GamingBolt, 21 September 2026). Both are treated in the Conclusion as horizon rather than evidence. Konami's remake of *Snake Eater*, produced without Kojima, enters only as a phenomenon of reception.

Authorship. "Kojima" designates here what Foucault (1969) called an author-function: a principle of grouping and attribution laid over a collective practice that includes, among many others, the character and mechanical designer Yoji Shinkawa and the composers Harry Gregson-Williams and Ludvig Forssell. The possessory credit "A Hideo Kojima Game" is not a neutral signature but an object of analysis in its own right. Its contested fate in 2015 – Konami's removal of the studio's emblem from *The Phantom Pain*'s packaging even as the game re-announced Kojima's name at the opening of each mission – is read in Chapter 7 as a symptom of the corpus's own preoccupation with amputated and phantom authority.

Two orders of claim. The argument distinguishes throughout between *genealogical* claims, which concern sources Kojima cites, names, or unmistakably encodes (Dawkins's meme, Abe's rope, Huizinga's *Homo ludens*, the Melvillean names of *The Phantom Pain*), and claims of *elective affinity* – Goethe's *Wahlverwandtschaften* as Weber repurposed it – which concern convergences no influence can be shown to explain (Le Guin, Weil, Watsuji, Kant). The former are reconstructions; the latter are constructions, offered as instruments of interpretation. The prose marks the difference by its verbs: Kojima *draws on* or *cites* the first class; his work *converges with* or *rhymes with* the second.

Conventions. Games are cited by title and year of first release; theoretical works by author and year of first publication in the original language. In-game dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted, both because localizations diverge and out of respect for the integrity of copyrighted texts; public-domain sources are quoted where their exact wording carries the argument. Japanese writers and scholars appear in Japanese name order with macrons (Abe Kōbō, Watsuji Tetsurō, Azuma Hiroki, Murakami Takashi); Kojima appears in the Western order under which he publishes internationally. In-world terms retain the capitalization of the source texts (the Beach, Beached Things or BTs, the Patriots, Outer Heaven). The analysis presupposes familiarity with the resolutions of the works discussed.

The Stick, the Rope, and the Hand Between

0.1 The Problem of the Two Kojimas

Few authors in any medium have been so persistently divided against themselves by their critics. On one side stands the Kojima of the *Metal Gear* saga: architect of the stealth-action genre, satirist of nuclear deterrence and the military-industrial complex, postmodern ironist whose sequels interrogate their predecessors, and — in the most durable charge against him — a frustrated filmmaker whose cutscenes swell until the game seems a pretext for the cinema it envies, a charge he has half-embraced in his oft-repeated self-description as a body composed largely of films. On the other side stands the Kojima of *Death Stranding*: inventor of a self-declared new genre, the "strand game," whose protagonist is not a soldier but a courier, whose principal verb is not to shoot but to carry, and whose asynchronous multiplayer architecture rewards players for building ladders, bridges, and roads that strangers will use and never repay. Between the two lies the rupture of 2015, when Kojima's departure from Konami, the truncation of *The Phantom Pain*, and the cancellation of *Silent Hills* appeared to sever his career at the joint. The critical narrative that has grown around this rupture is a narrative of conversion: the maker of weapons lays down the stick and takes up the rope.

This thesis rejects the conversion narrative — not because the transformation it names is illusory, but because it misdescribes the transformation's logic. The rope was always inside the stick-game, and the stick survives inside the rope-game. Stealth, Kojima's foundational design decision, taken under the sprite limitations of the MSX2 home computer, is an aesthetics of avoidance in which the optimal soldier passes unseen and kills no one. *Peace Walker* (2010) and *The Phantom Pain* (2015) make their signature mechanic the Fulton surface-to-air recovery system, borrowed from Cold War aeronautics: a balloon on a cord that lifts a tranquilized enemy off the battlefield and delivers him to Mother Base, where he becomes a comrade. The enemy is not destroyed but carried, and in being carried he is converted. Conversely,

Death Stranding equips its porter with an item named, without irony, the Strand – a cord used to bind and subdue – and furnishes its purgatorial Beaches with the battlefields of the twentieth century, while *Death Stranding 2* readmits the apparatus of armed conflict into a world its predecessor had largely disarmed. The stick and the rope are not successive phases. They are, in a sense this thesis will make precise, *chiral counterparts*: figures identical in their elements and opposite in their orientation, which can be brought into correspondence by reflection but never by superposition.

The point is not merely corrective. If the stick and the rope are counterparts rather than stages, then the corpus is not the record of a career that changed its mind but the unfolding of a single problem through its possible solutions. That problem, stated as generally as possible, is the problem of *transmission under conditions of rupture*: how anything – a genome, a meme, a loyalty, a language, a cargo, a child – passes across a gap that ought to have severed it, and what becomes of those who carry it, those who receive it, and those who are carried. Kojima's answer, reconstructed here, is neither the soldier's nor the courier's alone. It is the answer of the hand that holds both.

0.2 State of the Question

The critical literature on Kojima remains disproportionate to his standing. It falls into three families. The first is exegetical: an immense, largely para-academic body of wikis, timelines, and video essays devoted to reconstructing the lore of the *Metal Gear* chronology and the allusive density of its dialogue. This family is itself a phenomenon the corpus anticipates. Ōtsuka Eiji's theory of narrative consumption (1989) describes precisely such a practice, in which consumers purchase fragments in order to reconstruct the "world" (*sekai*) concealed behind them; the *Metal Gear* timeline, deliberately released out of chronological order, is an Ōtsukan grand narrative assembled by its public. The second family is academic and thematic: studies of Japanese nuclear discourse in games (Hutchinson 2019), of military play after September 11 (Payne 2016), of metafiction and the player's interpellation in *Sons of Liberty*, and of procedural rhetoric in the sense of Bogost (2007). The third family, still forming, concerns *Death Stranding*: its network aesthetics (in the lineage of Jagoda 2016), its eerie pre-pandemic timing – released in November 2019, months before lockdowns made delivery workers "essential" – and the objection that it romanticizes logistics labor.

Three lacunae run across all three families. No study treats the corpus as a single system whose elements transform one another across titles. The genealogy of Kojima's ideas has rarely been pursued beyond the most visible citations, Dawkins and Abe, into the theorists, strategists, and mythographers who stand behind the work's architecture. And the corpus has been read as an illustration of philosophy

rather than as a contribution to it – as a site where Baudrillard or Foucault may be *recognized*, rather than as a body of thought that might correct, extend, or recombine them. This thesis addresses all three.

0.3 Research Questions

The inquiry is organized by five questions. First, what is the philosophical content of the motifs Kojima has himself named as the organizing themes of his work – *gene*, *meme*, *scene*, and *sense* for the four numbered *Metal Gear Solid* titles, *race* and *revenge* for *The Phantom Pain*, *connection* and its interrogation for the *Death Stranding* diptych? Second, from which originators do these motifs descend, and how faithfully, or how productively, does the corpus misread them? Third, how do Kojima's treatments compare with the canonical speculative, mythological, and philosophical fictions that address the same problems – cloning, simulation, linguistic weaponry, the return of the dead? Fourth, is there a single structure that generates the corpus's variants, and if so, what is it? Fifth, what does that structure imply for the theory of the medium itself?

0.4 The Argument in Five Propositions

P1. The morphology of the line. The corpus is a single, self-transforming myth-system whose master-figure is the line. Its protagonists are serpents (Naked, Solid, Liquid, Solidus, Venom) and, finally, a porter named Bridges. The serpent and the strand are transformations of one morpheme, and the corpus explores that morpheme's three topologies: the line *severed* (the stick, the weapon, deterrence), the line *closed upon itself* (the ouroboros: repetition, revenge, simulation, control), and the line *extended toward an other* (the strand, the bridge, the cord between the living and the dead).

P2. Chiral inheritance. Every regime of transmission in the corpus – genetic, memetic, scenic, sensory, linguistic, infrastructural – is structured as Kant's incongruent counterparts (1768) and Kelvin's chirality: the heir is the mirror-image of the ancestor, identical in content and non-superposable in orientation. Catastrophe follows from every attempt to force coincidence between heir and ancestor; ethical life follows from the acceptance of handedness.

P3. The Dead Hand. Across its nuclear, juridical, political, and metaphysical registers, the corpus isolates a single antagonist: the rule of the dead over the living – mortmain. Its heroes' task is to convert the dead hand into the living hand: to repatriate rather than resurrect, to hold in custody rather than in dominion.

P4. Mutually Assured Delivery. The corpus develops a ludic counter-doctrine to Mutually Assured Destruction, which preserves deterrence's structural insight – that total interdependence pacifies – while inverting its valence from shared threat to

shared burden. Kojima's own multiplayer designs furnish the experimental evidence: *The Phantom Pain*'s Forward Operating Bases instantiate deterrence; *Death Stranding*'s Strand system instantiates delivery. *Death Stranding 2* then exposes the counter-doctrine's autoimmune vulnerability and matures it into an ethic of restraint and deferral.

P5. The metaxic medium. For Kojima, the videogame is the paradigmatic medium of the *between* – Plato's *metaxy*, Weil's *metaxu*, Watsuji's *aidagara*, the Japanese aesthetic interval *ma*. Its player–avatar relation is itself chiral; its metaleptic and asynchronous forms realize the figure of a wall that separates and communicates at once; and its highest vocation is the custody of the two beings who dwell between, the unborn and the dead.

0.5 Method

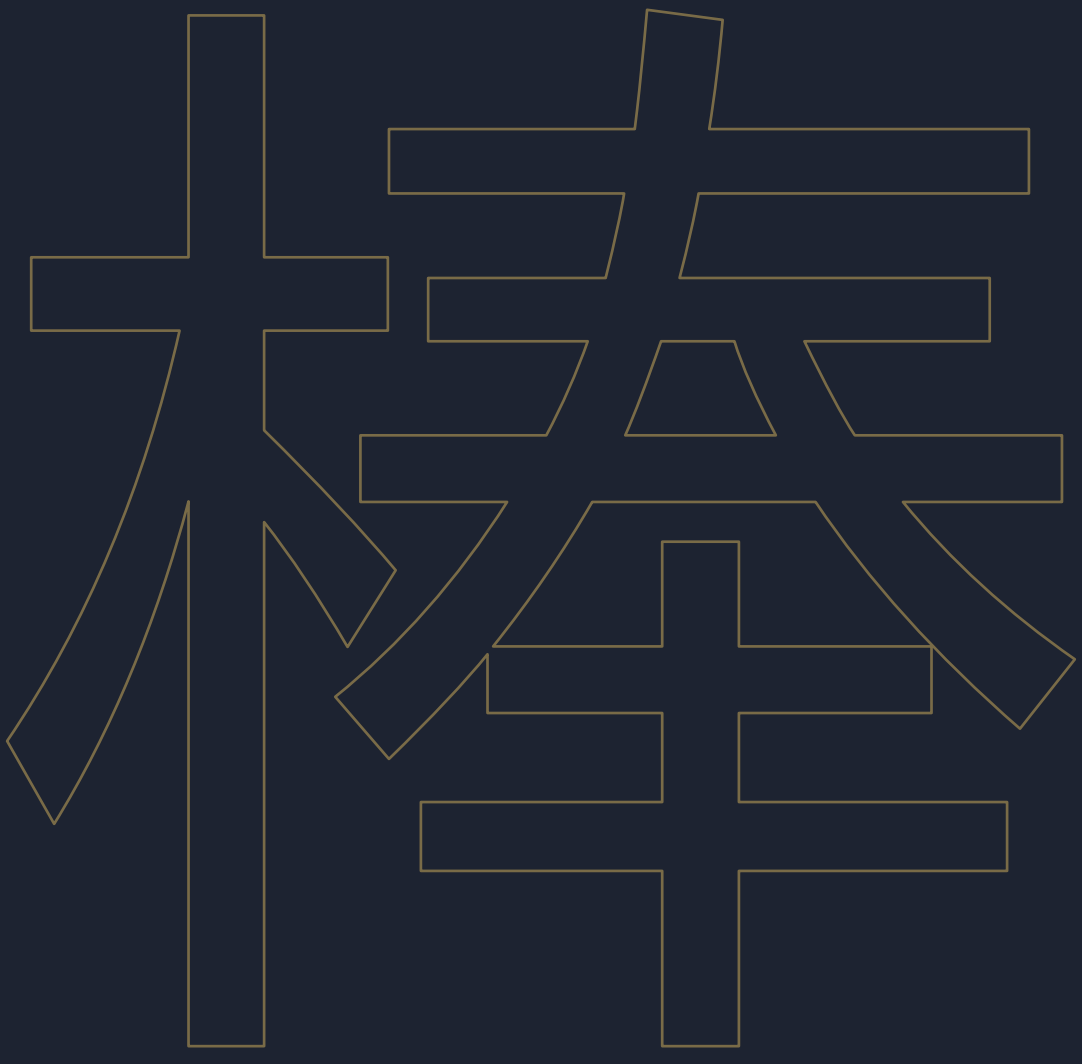
The method is plural by necessity, but its components are ordered. Its spine is structural. Lévi-Strauss (1955) proposed that a myth consists of all its versions, and that its meaning lies not in any single telling but in the transformations that relate the tellings to one another. The *Metal Gear* saga, with its clones, doubles, retcons, and chronological scrambling, is a transformation group almost by design; the *Death Stranding* diptych transforms it again. Kojima's own thematic vocabulary – gene, meme, scene, sense – is treated as an emic taxonomy, a native theory of the myth offered by its teller, to be tested rather than adopted.

Around this spine are arranged four auxiliary procedures. *Genealogical reconstruction* traces Kojima's declared and encoded sources, under the distinction between genealogy and elective affinity set out in the Prefatory Note. *Procedural analysis*, following Bogost's (2007) account of rhetoric enacted through rule systems and Aarseth's (1997) account of ergodic texts that require non-trivial effort to traverse, locates meaning in mechanics: in the Fulton balloon, the absence of a dislike button, the sniper who dies of old age if the player stops playing. *Media archaeology*, after Kittler (1986), Bazin (1945), and Galloway (2004), reads the corpus's fictional technologies – nanomachines, AIs, chiral networks – as theories of mediation in their own right. *Comparative mythopoetics* sets the corpus beside its analogues, with two cautions: against the universalism of Campbell's monomyth (1949), whose Jungian archetypes dissolve historical specificity, the comparison privileges structural relation over thematic resemblance; and against the Eurocentrism of the comparative canon, it treats the Japanese mythic and philosophical substrate – the *Kojiki*, the Kyoto School, Watsuji – as primary rather than exotic. Speculative fiction is read throughout as a philosophical genre in Suvin's (1979) sense: the literature of cognitive estrangement, organized around a *novum*. Kojima's nova – the clone, the meme-AI, the emotion-regulating nanomachine, the language parasite, the chiral network – are thought experiments, and they will be read as such.

A word on intention. Wimsatt and Beardsley (1946) warned against the intentional fallacy, and Barthes (1967) pronounced the author dead. Kojima is an inconvenient case for both. His paratextual presence is enormous – interviews, essays, a social-media practice of public annotation – and his name is inscribed in the works themselves with a frequency that borders on the liturgical. This thesis treats his statements as paratexts in Genette's (1987) sense: thresholds of the work rather than keys to it. They are evidence of what the corpus claims to be doing, to be weighed against what it does.

0.6 Architecture of the Argument

The thesis proceeds in five parts. **Part I, "The Stick,"** reads the founding *Metal Gear* titles, *Metal Gear Solid*, *Snake Eater*, and *Peace Walker* as an inquiry into deterrence, genetic inheritance, and the betraying father, culminating in a machine that refuses to strike. **Part II, "The Meme,"** reads *Sons of Liberty* and *Guns of the Patriots* as the passage from biological to informational inheritance and from discipline to control, and introduces the figure of the Dead Hand. **Part III, "The Phantom,"** reads *The Phantom Pain* and *P.T.* as works of mourning – of lost tongues, lost limbs, lost selves, and lost works – and locates in them the corpus's most radical meditation on identity as prosthesis. **Part IV, "The Strand,"** reads the *Death Stranding* diptych as an ontology of connection that is simultaneously a necro-logistics, an eschatology, and a self-critique. **Part V, "Synthesis,"** constructs the three theoretical instruments – chiral inheritance, Mutually Assured Delivery, and the metaxic medium – toward which the readings converge. The Conclusion assesses the contribution, its limits, and the open horizon of works still in progress.



Part I

The Stick

Deterrence, Genes, and the Fathers

In the epigraph with which *Death Stranding* opens, Abe Kōbō names the stick and the rope as humanity's first tools: the stick to hold harm at a distance, the rope to draw the good near. Part I reads the works in which the stick governs. Its politics is deterrence, the doctrine of the weapon that works by not being used. Its kinship structure is paternal, organized around a father who commands, betrays, and must be killed more than once. Its theory of inheritance is genetic, and its characteristic catastrophe is the attempt to reproduce the father exactly. Yet in each of these works the rope is already present in the interstices of the stick, and the part closes on a weapon that drowns itself rather than fire.

1

Outer Heaven

The Soldier's Heterotopia and the Grammar of Deterrence

1.1 Stealth: The Stick That Refuses to Strike

The genre Kojima founded was born of a deficit. The MSX2 could not render enough moving sprites to sustain the firefights of contemporaneous action games, and Kojima, who has credited prison-escape cinema such as *The Great Escape* (1963) with the alternative, inverted the premise: the player would not overpower the enemy but evade him. The consequence was not merely a genre but a phenomenology. The stealth game is organized around the gaze of the Other, rendered as a vision cone on the guard's face and, in *Metal Gear Solid* (1998), diagrammed on the Soliton radar as a field of triangles sweeping the floor plan. The decisive event of such a game is the moment of being seen – the exclamation mark above the guard's head, the alarm, the shift of music into a register of panic.

Sartre's analysis of the look (1943) provides the canonical description of this event. A man crouched at a keyhole, absorbed in what he sees, hears footsteps in the corridor behind him; in that instant he becomes an object for another consciousness, and the absorption of the voyeur collapses into shame. The stealth player lives permanently on the threshold of Sartre's corridor. His mastery consists in seeing without being seen, which places him in the structural position of Bentham's inspector, whose tower in the Panopticon (1791) Foucault (1975) made the emblem of disciplinary power. The radar is a miniature panoptic diagram. But the player occupies this sovereign position while remaining, in body, the most vulnerable figure on the map: one man without support, whose discovery is fatal. Stealth thus confers the gaze of power upon the subject of exposure, and the genre's tension is the oscillation between these two positions.

The ethical consequence was latent from 1987 and explicit by 2004. Because detection is failure, the optimal play of a stealth game tends toward the non-event: no alarm, no witness, no corpse. The later titles formalize this tendency in tranquilizer weapons, close-quarters techniques of restraint, and ranking systems that reward the run in which no one dies. The weapon in a stealth game is a weapon held in reserve, and its highest use is its non-use. This is the first and most consequential sense in which the rope inhabits the stick. It is also the hinge that joins Kojima's design practice to his political subject. Stealth is deterrence at the scale of the body: in both, power resides in a capacity that succeeds only so long as it is not exercised. The infiltrator who never fires and the arsenal that is never launched obey the same grammar.

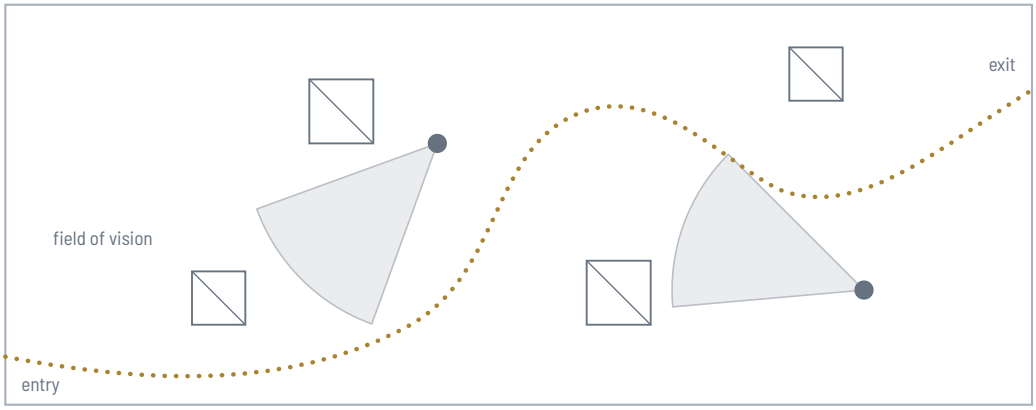


Figure 1.1 *The economy of the unused weapon. The infiltrator's path threads the gaps between fields of vision; success is measured by what never happens.*

1.2 Outer Heaven: A Heterotopia for Soldiers

Metal Gear (1987) sends a rookie operative, Solid Snake, into Outer Heaven, a fortified mercenary state in southern Africa, to destroy a nuclear-armed walking tank. *Metal Gear 2: Solid Snake* (1990) sends him into Zanzibar Land, a militarized enclave in Central Asia, on a structurally identical errand. In both, the enemy commander is revealed to be Big Boss, the legendary soldier who leads Snake's own unit, and in both his ambition is the same: a nation of soldiers, in which those whom states employ and discard would possess a homeland of their own and a permanent livelihood in war.

Foucault's "Of Other Spaces" (1967) supplies the category for this ambition. Heterotopias are real places that represent, contest, and invert all the other sites of a culture: the cemetery, the prison, the colony, the brothel, the ship. Outer Heaven is a heterotopia of the military itself – the barracks raised to the dignity of a state, the

institution that serves the nation turned into the nation it serves. It is significant that the corpus's heterotopias are so persistently maritime. The Big Shell of *Sons of Liberty* is an offshore decontamination platform; Liquid Ocelot's Outer Haven in *Guns of the Patriots* is a warship; Mother Base in *Peace Walker* and *The Phantom Pain* is a complex of offshore struts; the DHV Magellan of *Death Stranding 2* is a vessel. Foucault closed his lecture by calling the ship the heterotopia par excellence and the greatest reserve of the imagination, warning that in civilizations without boats dreams dry up. Kojima's corpus is a civilization of boats, and its dreams are of homelands that float because they have no ground. The image has a domestic origin as well: Kojima's father, whose great regret was never having joined the navy, built model warships and castles at home and made his son watch how he painted their seams.

The name itself carries a further charge. A heaven for soldiers is an afterlife, and its mythic prototype is Valhalla, where Odin's chosen dead, the *einherjar*, fight each day, fall, rise again at evening, and feast. Eternal war as paradise is the secret content of Big Boss's utopia, and it is also, uncomfortably, the formal content of the videogame, whose respawn mechanics grant every fallen soldier a nightly resurrection. Outer Heaven is Valhalla secularized, and the game that depicts it is Valhalla automated.

Carl Schmitt's *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) sharpens the contradiction at its core. Schmitt defined the partisan by four criteria – irregularity, mobility, intensity of political commitment, and a *telluric* character, a bond to a particular soil that he regarded as the partisan's ultimate limit and legitimacy. Big Boss's mercenaries satisfy the first three and repudiate the fourth. *Peace Walker* names his force Militaires Sans Frontières, parodying the humanitarian Médecins Sans Frontières founded in 1971: soldiers without borders, partisans without soil. Deleuze and Guattari's account of the nomadic war machine in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) names what such a force is. The war machine, on their account, is exterior to the State, which can only appropriate it in the form of the military institution. Big Boss's project is the attempt of a war machine to become a State without ceasing to be a war machine – to settle while remaining nomadic, to found a homeland for the homeless. The attempt is self-contradictory, and the contradiction is Big Boss's tragedy across five decades of fictional history.

1.3 The Grammar of Deterrence

Within a year of Hiroshima, Bernard Brodie's *The Absolute Weapon* (1946) drew the conclusion on which the Cold War would be built: the purpose of military establishments, hitherto to win wars, must henceforth be to avert them. Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) pursued the logic to the Doomsday Machine, a device that would destroy the world automatically if attacked – the ideal deterrent in the-

ory, he argued, and unacceptable in practice. Thomas Schelling's *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960) recast deterrence as a form of bargaining in which credibility is everything, and in which a rational actor may gain by binding himself to irrational commitments, including what he called the threat that leaves something to chance. Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) made the Doomsday Machine a joke the world has never stopped telling.

The central insight of this tradition is that a deterrent weapon is a *sign*. It operates through communication – through being known, attributed, and believed – and its ideal career is to signify forever without ever being used. Kojima's Metal Gears are designed as attacks on this semiotics. A nuclear-capable walking tank renders the launch platform mobile and therefore unlocatable, and *Metal Gear Solid*'s REX is engineered to deliver a warhead by railgun, without the launch signature by which deterrence identifies its author. A weapon that cannot be attributed cannot deter, because deterrence depends on knowing whom one would destroy in return. Each Metal Gear is thus a threat not only to cities but to the grammar that has kept cities intact, and each Snake mission restores that grammar by the intervention of a single body.

Kojima has described the childhood scene in which this grammar first became a question. He recalls a war film whose title he cannot remember, in which American and German forces, out of supplies and with casualties mounting, agree to a one-day ceasefire, and his bewilderment as a child: if the two sides could sit down and talk, why did they need to fight at all? (GamesRadar, 2015). The child's question is Schelling's discovery read in reverse. Schelling showed that enemies are always communicating, that conflict is a form of bargaining carried on through threats, signals, and tacit agreements, and drew from this a doctrine in which peace is kept by communication made credible through terror. The child asks why the communication should need the war at all. History records the same structure in the unofficial truces along the Western Front at Christmas 1914, and in what Tony Ashworth (1980) called the trenches' "live and let live" system, in which opposing units learned to restrain their fire in tacit reciprocity; Robert Axelrod (1984) made that system a central historical case of cooperation emerging between enemies. The corpus answers the child twice. The *Metal Gear* saga explores the grammar in which talk is backed by the threat of annihilation. *Death Stranding*, whose purgatorial Beaches return the porter to the trenches of the First World War (Chapter 9), imagines a communication backed instead by carrying. A child's question about a half-remembered film is the seed of the counter-doctrine that Chapter 12 calls Mutually Assured Delivery.

Derrida's "No Apocalypse, Not Now" (1984) argued that nuclear war is "fabulously textual": having never occurred, it exists only in discourse, simulation, and rhetoric, and deterrence is a competence in fiction – the capacity to make an unprecedented event believable enough that it need never happen. On this account the *Metal Gear* saga is a body of nuclear criticism in narrative form. It stages again and again the

war that must not take place, and it does so in a medium of simulation whose players rehearse, in safety, the prevention of the unthinkable. Frances Ferguson's essay on the nuclear sublime, published in the same issue of *Diacritics*, describes the affect proper to this rehearsal: Kant's dynamical sublime, the might of nature contemplated from a position of safety, transposed to a human artifact that can annihilate the very position of safety from which it is contemplated.

Deleuze and Guattari supply the corpus's political horizon. In their analysis, the war machine, having passed through the State and through total war, takes *peace itself* as its object – the peace of terror and survival maintained by deterrence, more total than any war. Virilio and Lotringer would call this condition pure war (1983): war's preparation become permanent, its outbreak indefinitely deferred. Kojima's titles return obsessively to the word *peace* – *Peace Walker*, a girl named Paz who is an enemy agent, an order of Patriots who maintain stability by managing conflict – and in each case the word names the war machine's most refined product. Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) opens with the joke on which this entire tradition might be hung: a Dutch innkeeper's sign bearing the words "To Perpetual Peace" above a painted graveyard. Twice the saga closes at Arlington National Cemetery, before the grave of the woman whose will its world claimed to execute. The peace of deterrence is the peace of the churchyard, and Kojima knows it.

1.4 The Nuclear Inheritance: Godzilla and the Children of the Bomb

That a Japanese author should make nuclear deterrence the organizing problem of his life's work is overdetermined. The postwar Japanese imagination of the bomb found its founding myth in Honda Ishirō's *Godzilla* (1954), released months after the crew of the fishing boat *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* was irradiated by the American Castle Bravo test. Godzilla is the nuclear event given a body that walks. The Metal Gears are its techno-descendants, and the lineage is explicit in *Metal Gear Solid*'s REX, whose name, posture, and roar recall the tyrannosaur. Where Godzilla is the bomb as uncontrollable nature, REX is the bomb domesticated as a platform and then stolen – the monster returned to the hands of men who believe they can command it.

The corpus encodes the bomb as an inheritance in the most literal sense. In *Metal Gear Solid*, Hal "Otacon" Emmerich recounts that his grandfather worked on the Manhattan Project and that his father was born on the day the United States destroyed Hiroshima with an atomic bomb. His father, Huey, will build Peace Walker and Sahelanthropus; Hal builds REX. The Emmerich line is a house of Atreus whose ancestral crime is fission, and whose sons repeat it while abhorring it. *Sons of Liberty*'s bomb-maker is named Fatman, after the weapon dropped on Nagasaki. *Peace Walker*'s Kazuhira Miller is the son of an American serviceman and a Japanese mother, a child of the Occupation. Murakami Takashi's *Little Boy* (2005), named for the Hiroshima bomb, argued that postwar Japanese subculture is the expression of a

nation infantilized by defeat and by the protection of the power that defeated it. Kojima's corpus is crowded with children manufactured by war – cloned soldiers, child soldiers, fetal instruments, girls raised inside weapons – and Murakami's thesis gives their genealogy its historical ground. The children of the bomb are not a motif in Kojima. They are his cast.

Kojima's own productions extend the list. *Zone of the Enders* (2001), which he produced, places a boy in the cockpit of an orbital war machine after an attack on his space colony kills his friends: the child pilot of Japanese mecha fiction, recast as a survivor conscripted by catastrophe.

1.5 The Betraying Father and the Primal Horde

The founding structure of the saga is not deterrence, however, but betrayal. In both MSX2 titles, the commander who dispatches Snake and guides him by radio is the commander of the enemy. The father sends the son to die, and the son survives by killing the father. This is the plot of Laius and Oedipus with the oracle removed and the radio substituted, and it is also the plot of Kronos, who devoured his children to forestall the son who would overthrow him. Snake kills Big Boss in 1987 and kills him again in 1990. The father must be killed twice, because the first death does not take.

The paternal structure has a biographical threshold that the corpus's paratexts make difficult to ignore. Kojima's father, Kingo, a pharmacist, instituted a nightly family film: the children were not allowed to go to bed until it had finished. He had wanted to join the navy, but the war ended when he was fifteen; as a boy he had climbed onto rooftops to watch the bombs fall on Tokyo, and he grew up, in one journalist's summary, admiring soldiers and disgusted by war. He showed his son Alain Resnais's *Night and Fog* (1956), the documentary of the Nazi camps, which Kojima later said a child could not understand (GamesRadar, 2015). Kingo died suddenly when his son was thirteen, and the family entered a period of financial hardship (Wikipedia; AFP, via TechXplore). Kojima has described himself as left with a father complex, calling the *Metal Gear* games paternal stories, "all about killing your father"; he has also told *Edge* that the loss of his father was a major theme of the series, and that *Death Stranding 2* puts the player in the father's position rather than the child's (GamingBolt, reporting *Edge*).

Following the method set out in the Introduction, this thesis treats such facts as thresholds rather than keys. Two structural observations are nonetheless warranted. First, what this father transmitted was not a body but a practice, a habit of watching renewed each night, so that the son's first inheritance was memetic rather than genetic; the corpus's preference for what is chosen and passed on over what is merely carried in the blood has its first instance here. Second, the father's own ambivalence – admiration for soldiers, disgust at war – is the founding contradiction of a saga

that makes heroes of soldiers while arguing against every war they fight. The dead father left a cinema and a contradiction, and the son made both into a game.

Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) is the theory of that second death. In Freud's speculative anthropology, the brothers of the primal horde murder and devour the father who monopolized power, and then, overcome by guilt, institute the law in his name; the dead father becomes stronger than the living one had been. The later *Metal Gear* titles transpose this myth with remarkable fidelity. After the death of The Boss – the saga's primal parent, figured as a mother – her disciples found an order in her name, the Patriots, and quarrel over the meaning of her will. Their sons, in turn, war over Big Boss's body: *Metal Gear Solid*'s terrorists demand his remains, because his genome is the totem whose consumption confers his power. The cloning project that produced Solid and Liquid Snake is a totem meal conducted by molecular biology, a eucharist of the father's substance. The rest of Part I follows this meal to its consequences.

2

The Selfish Clone

Genes, Twins, and the Myth of the Inferior Brother

2.1 The Gene's-Eye View and Its Discontents

Kojima has named *gene* as the theme of *Metal Gear Solid* (1998), and the citation is precise. Dawkins's *The Selfish Gene* (1976) reconceived the organism as a "survival machine" built by replicators for their own propagation: the gene is the unit of selection and of quasi-immortality, the body its temporary vehicle. The fiction literalizes this ontology. Les Enfants Terribles, the cloning program that produced Solid and Liquid Snake from the genome of Big Boss, treats the legendary soldier as a replicator and his sons as vehicles – copies manufactured to carry the father's excellence forward without the father's consent or participation.

The drama of the game turns on a misreading of Mendel. Liquid Snake constructs his identity on the conviction that the program allotted his brother the father's dominant genes and himself the recessive ones – that he is the inferior copy, the remainder of a selection. His terrorism is a revenge on the genome. Yet dominance in Mendelian genetics denotes expression, not excellence: a recessive allele is not a lesser one, merely one that is masked in the heterozygote. Liquid's grievance rests on a category mistake, the conversion of a descriptive term into a value, which is the elementary error of vulgar genetic determinism, and the saga in later installments complicates even the factual attribution on which his resentment rests. The game does not refute genetic determinism by counter-argument. It exposes it as a story a wounded son tells himself.

Dawkins would have agreed. The book that popularized the selfish gene closes its meme chapter by insisting that human beings alone are capable of rebelling against the tyranny of their replicators. *Metal Gear Solid* closes on the same note, by other

means. Its epilogue turns from the question of what Snake *is* to the question of what he will choose – whom he will live for – and the geneticist Naomi Hunter, who engineered the weapon in his blood, urges him in effect to refuse the authority of his genome. The game thereby performs the passage its own sequel will name: from gene to meme, from what is inherited to what is chosen and passed on.

2.2 Les Enfants Terribles: Cocteau, Twins, and the Closed Room

The name of the cloning program is a citation of Jean Cocteau's novel *Les Enfants terribles* (1929), in which the siblings Paul and Élisabeth inhabit a sealed room and play what Cocteau calls simply "the Game" – a private world of ritual, hoarding, and mutual torment that the adult world cannot penetrate. When that world finally intrudes, the game turns lethal, and both siblings die. The resonance with the Snakes is more than nominal. Clones raised as instruments of a program, bound to each other by an identity that excludes everyone else, conduct their rivalry as a closed game whose only possible ending is death. Cocteau gave the program its name; he also gave it its structure, which is that of a game played in a room with no exit. The medium in which the Snakes appear is itself a game played in a room, and the novel's title, read in this light, is a quiet indictment of its own audience.

The fratricidal twin is among the oldest figures of the mythic archive, and the saga recapitulates its principal variants. Cain kills Abel because the father accepts one offering and refuses the other (Genesis 4); Liquid's resentment is Cain's, directed at a father who never chose. Jacob and Esau struggle in the womb, and Jacob obtains the blessing by deceiving a blind father (Genesis 25–27); Liquid casts himself as the defrauded Esau, and Big Boss, absent from the experiment that made his sons, is a blind Isaac who blessed no one. Romulus kills Remus and founds Rome on the body of his brother; every Outer Heaven in the saga is a Rome founded on fratricide. Eteocles and Polynices, the sons of Oedipus, kill each other at the gates of Thebes for their father's throne. Set dismembers his brother Osiris, whose body Isis gathers and reassembles – an Egyptian myth of fratricide, scattering, and the reconstitution of the dead that will return, transfigured, in the eschatology of *Death Stranding*.

René Girard supplies the theory that unifies these variants. In *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel* (1961) desire is mimetic: we desire according to a model, who becomes, as the rivalry intensifies, an obstacle. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) Girard argued that the dissolution of differences produces a sacrificial crisis, a spiral of reciprocal violence in which antagonists become "monstrous doubles" of one another, and that many cultures fear twins precisely because they embody this loss of difference. The clone is the maximal case of undifferentiation, the twin raised to the power of technology. Girard's crisis resolves through the expulsion of a scapegoat; in *Metal Gear Solid* it resolves through FOXDIE, a weapon that selects its victim by genome. The sacrificial mechanism, in Kojima, has been engineered.

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) describes the psychology of the brother who loses. The man of *ressentiment*, Nietzsche argues, needs a hostile external world in order to act at all; his action is fundamentally reaction, and his values are defined by negation of the values of another. Liquid is a pure instance. He has no project that is not a reversal of his brother's, and his final appearances – including the posthumous one in which his personality persists grafted onto another man – show a self that exists only as the shadow of a rivalry.

2.3 The Chiral Twins

The clone pair has a structure that the corpus will not name for two decades. In 1768 Kant observed that a left hand and a right hand are identical in every internal relation – the same parts, the same proportions, the same distances – yet cannot be made to occupy the same boundaries; no rotation brings one into coincidence with the other. He called such figures incongruent counterparts and used them first to argue for the reality of absolute space and later, in the *Prolegomena* (1783, §13), for space as a form of intuition rather than a relation among things. In the 1890s Lord Kelvin introduced the word *chirality*, from the Greek *kheir*, hand, for any figure that cannot be superposed on its mirror image. Pasteur had already shown, in 1848, that the crystals of tartaric acid exist in mirror-image forms, and had speculated that life itself is constitutively asymmetric. The twentieth century added the parable of thalidomide, whose mirror-image forms were long taught as the difference between a sedative and a teratogen – a parable complicated by the fact that the forms interconvert in the body, but no less powerful for that, and resonant in Japan, where the drug's victims were among the children of the postwar boom.

Solid and Liquid Snake are enantiomers. They share a composition and differ in orientation: the same genome, turned toward restraint in one and toward rage in the other, toward survival in one and toward revenge in the other. When *Death Stranding* (2019) builds its metaphysics on "chiral matter," it names retroactively the structure that governed Kojima's doubles from the start. Borges observed, in "Kafka and His Precursors" (1951), that every writer creates his own precursors, modifying our conception of the past as he will modify the future. Kojima's late work creates the chirality of his early work. Read through it, the saga's obsessive doubling – Solid and Liquid, Big Boss and Venom, Big Boss and Zero, Snake and Raiden, the player and the avatar – resolves into a single relation: the counterpart that can be reflected but not superposed.

Solidus Snake, the third and allegedly "perfect" product of the program, revealed in *Sons of Liberty*, completes the figure. If Solid and Liquid are enantiomers, Solidus aspires to the condition of the racemate – the equal mixture of opposed forms in which their rotations cancel. That this aspiration expresses itself as the attempt to

found a state is not incidental. Sovereignty, in Solidus's hands, is the fantasy of a neutrality produced by the cancellation of opposites. Chapter 4 returns to him.

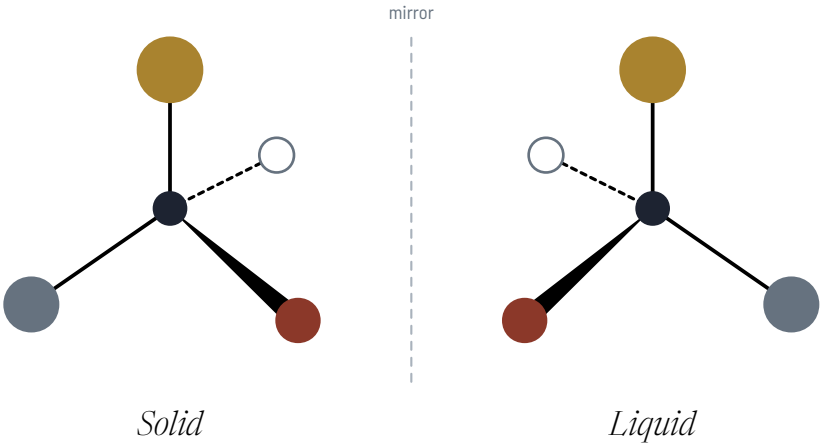


Figure 2.1 *Incongruent counterparts. A chiral pair shares every element and every internal relation, yet no rotation brings one into coincidence with the other.*

2.4 The Rights of Copies

The question of the copy precedes the Snakes in Kojima's work. *Snatcher* (1988) sets its hard-boiled cyberpunk in Neo Kobe City, where an amnesiac investigator hunts bioroids that murder human beings and assume their places. Its sources are legible in its title and its mise-en-scène: Jack Finney's *The Body Snatchers* (1955) and Don Siegel's film adaptation (1956), whose replacement of townspeople by emotionless duplicates condensed the Cold War's fear of conformity and infiltration, and Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), after Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), in which the replicant can be distinguished from the human only by a test of empathy. *Snatcher* adopts the original's point of view: the terror is of being replaced. *Metal Gear Solid* adopts the copy's: the grievance is of having been made. *Policenauts* (1994), whose detective drifts frozen in orbit for twenty-five years and wakes as a Rip Van Winkle of the space age, adds a third term. Its conspiracy turns on the trafficking of human organs, the body broken down into exchangeable parts – a commodification of flesh that returns, at the scale of the planet, in the war economy of *Guns of the Patriots* and the instrumentalized fetuses of *Death Stranding*.

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) remains the paradigm of the copy's grievance: the creature confronts a creator who fled from him and demands the recognition he was denied at birth. The *Metal Gear* saga adds a turn Shelley did not imagine. The father is himself a victim of the copying. Big Boss neither consented to nor directed the program that cloned him; his genome was taken, an early instance in fiction of

the self as expropriable data. The creator who fled is replaced by a progenitor who was robbed. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) offers the opposite case: clones raised for organ donation who accept their fate with a passivity more harrowing than revolt. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) offers a third, the mass production of identical humans by Bokanovsky's Process in the service of stability. Against these, Kojima's clones are an elite, manufactured not for docility or for parts but for war, and their violence is the violence of instruments that discovered they could ask to whom their lives belong.

Two further figures in *Metal Gear Solid* extend the question from the genome to the body and the mind. The Cyborg Ninja, revealed as Gray Fox — a former child soldier taken in by Big Boss, left for dead by Solid Snake in Zanzibar Land, and rebuilt in covert experiments as a weapon in a suit of pain — is a cyborg in Haraway's sense (1985): an entity in which organism and machine, myth and military technology, are fused beyond separation. His dying insistence that soldiers are not the tools of governments states the corpus's anti-instrumentalist ethic in its plainest form. Psycho Mantis, a telepath, demonstrates his power by reading the player's memory card and remarking on the other games saved there, and by commanding the player to set the controller on the floor so that he can move it. He can be defeated only when the player moves the controller to another port, physically reconfiguring the hardware to escape a mind-reader. The episode makes the player's stored data a substitute for the player's mind. Freud's "Note upon the 'Mystic Writing-Pad'" (1925) had modeled the psychic apparatus on a writing toy that retains its traces beneath an erasable surface; Kittler (1986) would argue that the storage media of modernity are the true unconscious. The memory card is a mystic writing pad, and Mantis reads it as an analyst reads a slip.

2.5 FOXDIE: The Genome as Criterion

FOXDIE, the engineered virus that the geneticist Naomi Hunter injected into Snake without his knowledge, on behalf of the Pentagon, and that he carries into Shadow Moses, recognizes the genetic markers of designated targets and stops their hearts. Its victims are chosen by DNA. One of them, the shape-shifter Decoy Octopus, dies because his disguise as a captive official extended to the official's blood: his imitation was so complete that it became genetic, and the weapon could not tell the copy from the original. Snake is the vector of a death he does not choose and does not know he carries; the hero is a delivery system.

The weapon's chain of command sharpens the reading. FOXDIE was a Pentagon program, and it was the Secretary of Defense, Jim Houseman, who ordered Naomi to inject Snake, so that the insurgents would die while REX, its test data, and the bodies of the Genome Soldiers were recovered intact. When Snake destroyed REX instead, Houseman ordered a nuclear strike on Shadow Moses to erase the evidence; it was

aborted by President Sears, who would return in *Sons of Liberty* as Solidus. Naomi, meanwhile, had secretly re-engineered the virus to kill Snake as well, at a moment even she could not predict (Giant Bomb; Giant Bomb). The state's targeted weapon carries a private revenge inside it. *Guns of the Patriots* completes the arc. The original strain is found to be mutating toward an indiscriminate pandemic that would turn its carrier into a walking weapon of mass destruction, and it is held in check only by a second strain, injected by Drebin on the Patriots' orders to kill EVA, Liquid Ocelot, and Big Boss. The selective weapon's terminal form is the unselective one. A criterion of death, left to evolve, erodes until it selects everyone, and the saga's history of weapons ends where *Death Stranding* begins: with extinction.

Foucault's biopower (1976) – the modern sovereign's power to make live and let die – and Mbembe's necropolitics (2003) – the power to dictate who may live and who must die – meet in FOXDIE, which renders the criterion of death a matter of molecular identity. But FOXDIE's greater significance lies in the series it inaugurates. Every subsequent catastrophe in the corpus is a theory of the criterion by which a weapon selects its victims. FOXDIE kills by genome. *The Phantom Pain*'s vocal cord parasites kill by language. *Death Stranding*'s voidouts are triggered by contact between the living and the dead. And *Death Stranding 2* asks whether connection itself has become the vector. The series moves from what one *is* to what one *says* to whom one *touches*: from biology to culture to relation. It is the corpus's theory of history, written as a sequence of weapons.



Figure 2.2 *The criterion of death. Each catastrophe selects its victims differently, moving from what one is, to what one says, to whom one touches, until the selection includes everyone.*

2.6 The Retraction of the Gene

Kojima's sequence from gene to meme is a polemic, and the corpus retracts the gene's claims in stages. Liquid's founding grievance is exposed as a misreading. The clones' fates diverge in ways their genomes do not predict. The genome's one incontestable verdict, delivered in *Guns of the Patriots*, is not destiny but mortality: the clones were engineered to age at an accelerated rate, so that the father's excellence would arrive with an expiry date. The gene's last word is that its vehicles die. What

persists is something else — what the vehicles choose to transmit. *Sons of Liberty* will call it the meme, and will discover that memes, too, can be made into a tyranny.

3

The Joy and the Sorrow

Loyalty, Sacrifice, and the Ouroboros

3.1 Scene: The Enemy and the Times

Metal Gear Solid 3: Snake Eater (2004) withdraws the saga to its origin, 1964, and Kojima's name for its theme is *scene*: the era, the configuration of time and place that determines what anything means within it. The game's philosophy is spoken by The Boss, mother of special forces and mentor to the young operative Naked Snake, who teaches that there are no enemies in any absolute sense – that enmity is assigned by the times, and that a soldier's loyalty to a nation is loyalty to something whose meaning changes with the era.

The proposition is legible against Carl Schmitt's *The Concept of the Political* (1932), for which the specific distinction of politics is that of friend and enemy. Schmitt's enemy is neither the morally evil nor the personally hated; he is the public enemy, designated by a political decision and defined by the existential possibility of combat. The Boss accepts Schmitt's formalism and adds time. If the enemy is a decision, the enemy is historical; what is decided may be undecided by the next era. Hegel's preface to the *Philosophy of Right* (1820), which describes philosophy as its own time apprehended in thought and every individual as a child of his time, supplies the historicist frame. But The Boss's tragedy is that she seeks a loyalty that escapes the scene altogether – a fidelity not to a nation, whose meaning shifts, but to the world as such. *Snake Eater* is the story of what it costs to be loyal to something that has no era.

3.2 The Cobra Unit: A Spinozan Machine of Affects

The Boss's unit, the Cobras, consists of soldiers named for what they bring to the battlefield: The Pain, The Fear, The End, The Fury, The Sorrow, and The Boss herself, whose codename in the unit is The Joy. Each dies in a spectacular dispersal that returns its affect to the world. The nomenclature is a psychology, and its closest philosophical analogue is the third part of Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677). Spinoza recognizes three primary affects – desire, joy, and sadness – and defines joy as the passage of a body to a greater power of acting and sadness as its passage to a lesser. Pain is a sadness of the body; fear is an inconstant sadness born of doubt about the future; anger is the desire to harm what we hate. The Cobras are a Spinozan machine: a unit assembled not from genes, as the clones were, but from affects.

The structure of the unit encodes the structure of the tragedy. Joy and Sorrow are lovers – The Boss and the spirit medium called The Sorrow – and their son is Ocelot, the saga's supreme double agent, the being of the in-between. The Boss killed The Sorrow on orders; Naked Snake kills The Boss on orders. The young soldier's passage through the game is thus a passage through every affect to the destruction of joy itself, and his subsequent history as Big Boss is a Spinozan descent. For Spinoza, hatred is sadness accompanied by the idea of an external cause. Big Boss's hatred of Zero, of the Patriots, of the system that used him, is the sorrow of 1964 projected onto an object. *Guns of the Patriots* will close the arc by restoring joy, in a cemetery, at the end of a life.

The Cobras also complete a classificatory system that runs the length of the saga. FOXHOUND's renegades in *Metal Gear Solid* are named for animals: fox, wolf, raven, octopus, mantis, ocelot. *Guns of the Patriots* fuses the animal and the affect in the Beauty and the Beast Unit: Laughing Octopus, Raging Raven, Crying Wolf, Screaming Mantis, each a woman traumatized by war inside an armored beast. Lévi-Strauss's study of totemism (1962) argued that natural species are chosen as emblems not because they are useful to eat but because they are good to think: animal differences provide a grid for classifying human ones. Kojima's bestiary is a totemic grid laid over the psyche of the soldier. The animals classify roles; the affects classify wounds; the synthesis of the two in 2008 shows the wound becoming the role.

3.3 The End: The Player's Time and the Vegetable Soldier

The End is a sniper of about a hundred years, sustained in part by photosynthesis, whose duel with the player is an exercise in duration: a slow search through forest for a man who does not move. Should the player save during the encounter and return a week later, The End will have died of old age. *Snake Eater* lets provisions spoil

in real time; *Boktai* (2003) had already required its player to carry the cartridge into actual sunlight, measured by a photometric sensor, to charge a solar weapon. In each case the time of the world outside the game breaches the time of the game. Kojima's *scene* is literalized as the player's own calendar.

Bergson's distinction between lived duration and spatialized clock-time (1889) describes the texture of The End's encounter, which forces the player out of the segmented time of action into the continuous time of waiting. Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death (1927), in which death is one's ownmost and non-relational possibility, describes its structure: The End is a being whose death is so near that it can be reached by doing nothing. Spinoza had written that a free man thinks of nothing less than of death, and that his wisdom is a meditation not on death but on life. The End can be defeated by the free man's method – by going away and living. The vegetal sniper prefigures a figure the corpus will develop, the soldier who has ceased to require prey: *The Phantom Pain*'s Quiet breathes through her skin, and the plant-soldier is one of the corpus's quiet images of a war that has begun to make peace inside its own bodies.

3.4 The Sorrow's River: A Nekyia for the Player

The Sorrow does not fight. His encounter is a walk upstream through a shallow river while the ghosts of every soldier the player has killed approach, so that the length and density of the procession are a function of the player's own violence. To die in the river is to reach a counterfeit game-over screen from which the player escapes by swallowing a revival pill, a feigned death that releases a real life.

The episode is a *nekyia*, the epic descent to the dead. Odysseus summons the shades with blood in the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*; Aeneas crosses into the underworld in the sixth book of the *Aeneid* and sees the souls who will drink from Lethe and forget; Dante descends past Acheron to the frozen Cocytus. The Sorrow's river inverts the Lethe: it is a river of remembering, which returns to the player the dead he has made. Its closest analogue in modern literature is Wilfred Owen's "Strange Meeting" (1918), in which a soldier escapes down a tunnel into hell and meets a man who tells him, "I am the enemy you killed, my friend." Owen's poem is a single such meeting; The Sorrow is "Strange Meeting" as procedure, iterated across every kill.

Two consequences follow. First, the game's memory of the player's acts converts play into a moral archive – a ledger that the player cannot see until it is presented as a procession. This is the germ of *Death Stranding*'s Beached Things, the unrepatriated dead who press upon the living, and of its persistent craters, which preserve the record of failure in the world. Second, The Sorrow is a *medium* in both senses of the word. The nineteenth century's spiritualist mediums and its telegraphs arose together and borrowed each other's metaphors, as Jeffrey Sconce (2000) and Kittler (1986)

have shown. The Sorrow is the game's figure for itself: the apparatus through which the dead speak to the one who has made them.

3.5 The Boss: Antigone, Abraham, and the Silent Sacrifice

The Boss's defection to the Soviet Union, carrying two portable nuclear weapons, is revealed after her death to have been a mission. Washington had arranged the defection as cover for a covert operation. When the Soviet colonel Volgin fired one of her weapons on Soviet soil, and Khrushchev demanded proof that the United States was not behind the strike, Washington ordered her killed as a traitor, by her own student, so that a nuclear war might be averted. She could disclose her purpose to no one, least of all the disciple sent to kill her. Her grave at Arlington is unmarked.

Hegel's reading of *Antigone* in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) opposes the divine law of the family, which owes the dead their burial, to the human law of the state, which may refuse it. The Boss inverts Antigone. She sacrifices the family – her lover, her disciple, the son taken from her at birth – to the state, and then sacrifices the state's own claim on her to a third law that Hegel's dialectic does not contain: the world. The final scene of *Snake Eater* restores Antigone's act to its place. Before an unmarked grave that the state has denied a name, Naked Snake salutes. The disciple performs the funerary honor the city withholds, and becomes, in that gesture, the Antigone of his own tragedy.

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) supplies the deeper structure. The tragic hero – Agamemnon sacrificing Iphigenia for the city – remains within the ethical: he can speak, be understood, and be wept for. The knight of faith – Abraham on the way to Moriah – suspends the ethical for an absolute relation to God, and his mark is silence: he cannot explain himself, because any explanation would return him to the universal. The Boss is a knight of faith whose absolute is the world. She cannot speak; she appears to everyone as a traitor; and what she sacrifices is herself, so that Abraham and Isaac are collapsed into one figure, with the disciple as the hand that holds the knife. Kierkegaard's third *Problema* asks whether Abraham was ethically justified in concealing his undertaking. The saga answers with a catastrophe. EVA's posthumous disclosure converts The Boss from a knight of faith into a tragic hero, an act now explicable, and the explanation destroys the disciple. Naked Snake learns that he killed the person he loved for a reason the state will never acknowledge, and the knowledge makes him Big Boss: the soldier who will spend his life refusing to be an instrument, by building instruments of his own.

3.6 Ouroboros: The All Is One

The mission is named Snake Eater; the player eats snakes for stamina; the saga is a snake eating snakes. Its emblem is the ouroboros, and the emblem's history bears

directly on the argument. The earliest known ouroboros appears on a gilded shrine from the tomb of Tutankhamun, in the funerary corpus scholars call the Enigmatic Book of the Netherworld: an Egyptian image of cyclical time in the context of death and the soul's passage. In Greco-Egyptian alchemy the serpent devouring its tail encircles the motto *hen to pan*, "the all is one," in the *Chrysopoeia* attributed to Cleopatra the Alchemist. The Boss's ideal of a world made one is thus, in its iconographic genealogy, the motto inscribed inside the self-devouring serpent. When Zero's Patriots realize her dream as total control, they do not betray the ideal so much as complete its emblem: unity achieved as closure, the world as a serpent with its tail in its mouth.

Nietzsche supplies the counter-image. In "On the Vision and the Riddle" (*Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Part III, 1884), Zarathustra sees a young shepherd choking on a heavy black snake that has crawled into his throat. He cries out, *Bite!* The shepherd bites off the snake's head, spits it away, and rises transformed, laughing as no man has laughed. The snake is the nausea of eternal recurrence; the bite is its affirmation. *Snake Eater* is a title that poses Nietzsche's riddle. Naked Snake does not bite; he is swallowed. He spends the rest of his history repeating his teacher's tragedy, founding states for soldiers as she died for a world, and becoming the father his own sons are sent to kill. Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) describes archaic societies that abolish history by repeating archetypal acts; the Patriots, and Big Boss in opposition to them, are moderns who abolish history the same way. The rest of the corpus is a search for the bite.

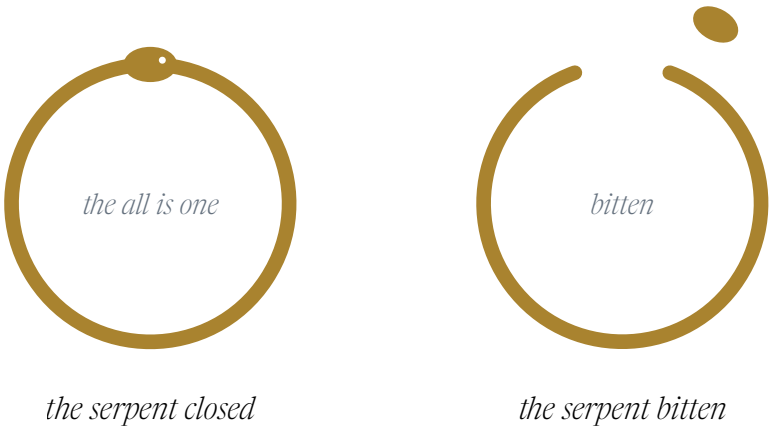


Figure 3.1 *The serpent closed and the serpent bitten: unity achieved as closure, and the bite that opens the loop.*

3.7 Peace Walker: The Machine That Would Not Strike

Peace Walker (2010) is set in 1974 in Costa Rica, a nation that abolished its army in 1948 and enshrined the abolition in its constitution of 1949. Its antagonist, the CIA officer Hot Coldman, has built an artificial intelligence that will retaliate with nuclear weapons automatically, on the theory that deterrence fails because human beings hesitate. The argument is Kahn's Doomsday Machine and Schelling's doctrine of commitment, operationalized; its historical counterpart is the Soviet Perimeter system, the semi-automatic retaliation network known as the Dead Hand, whose history David Hoffman documented (2009). Coldman's machine is the stick perfected: a weapon whose credibility is absolute because no one can stay its hand.

Kojima installs a ghost in this machine. Its core contains a reconstruction of The Boss's personality, built by a scientist who loved her. The dead mother's mind is made the guarantor of nuclear retaliation — the Dead Hand literalized as a dead woman's will in a weapon. The development stages of the program's machines bear the names of metamorphosis: Pupa, Chrysalis, Cocoon, and finally Peace Walker, the imago. Ovid's and Kafka's metamorphoses are transformations of bodies; this one is the maturation of a weapon toward its perfect form.

The climax reverses the metamorphosis. After the battle, the Boss-intelligence walks the machine into a lake and drowns itself. The guarantor of annihilation removes itself from the world. This is the most important event in Part I, and the hinge on which this thesis turns. The dead mind installed to rule the living declines to rule; the stick, at the moment of its perfection, refuses to strike and sinks. It is the first enactment in the corpus of the refusal of the Dead Hand, and the moment the rope begins to pull against the stick from within it.

Big Boss misreads the event, as he misread his teacher. He accepts the title he once despised and founds a nation of soldiers. Paz, the game's emissary of peace, who first appears as a schoolgirl, is revealed as an agent of Zero's Cipher; in *Ground Zeroes* (2014) she is held, with the boy Chico, at Camp Omega, a United States detention site in Cuba modeled on the camp at Guantánamo Bay, by XOF, the covert unit commanded by Skull Face. Cassette recordings the player can recover document their torture there, including the sexual abuse of Paz, in which, the recordings imply, Chico was coerced to take part. XOF surgically implants a bomb in Paz's body, and a second one where the medic who removes the first will not look. Peace with a bomb inside it is the truth of the deterrent order. Peace with a second bomb, concealed so as to survive the disarming of the first, is the logic of the second-strike reserve, inscribed in a body. Paz throws herself from the rescue helicopter before the second device detonates, and shrapnel from the blast and the crash that follows, lodged in that same medic's skull, will grow into Venom Snake's horn: the physiology of ressentiment traced in Chapter 7 begins as a fragment of the bomb XOF hid in Paz's

body. The setting completes the allegory. Costa Rica, the nation without an army, lies across the Pacific from Japan, whose constitution of 1947 renounced war under the protection of another power's arsenal. Paz's codename is Pacifica Ocean. The two pacifist constitutions face each other across an ocean like incongruent counterparts, and *Peace Walker* asks of both what peace can mean when it is guarded by a machine designed never to hesitate.

Camp Omega gives the saga's critique of deterrence a juridical location. Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) called the camp the hidden paradigm of modern political space, the place where the state of exception becomes the rule, and his *State of Exception* (2003) was written while the United States held prisoners of its war on terror at Guantánamo Bay outside the ordinary protection of law. *Ground Zeroes*, released in 2014, sets the prologue to the saga's long revenge in such a camp. The atrocity committed there, by a unit of Zero's own organization under Skull Face's command, is the origin of every phantom in *The Phantom Pain*.

The camp has a precedent in Kojima's own formation. His father showed him Resnais's *Night and Fog* as a child (Chapter 1). Resnais made the film, with a commentary by Jean Cayrol, a survivor of Mauthausen, to warn that the camps' logic could recur, at a moment when torture and internment were already practiced in the Algerian War, and its title names the Nazi decree under which prisoners were abducted and made to disappear ([Wikipedia](<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Night_and_Fog_(1956_film)>)). *Ground Zeroes* stages exactly the recurrence Resnais feared: a black site in a new war, holding prisoners who have been made to disappear. The father's film returns as the son's prologue, and the game's camp is *Night and Fog* relocated to the Caribbean in the age of the war on terror.

The atrocity's mode of delivery belongs to the argument. The abuse is not shown but heard, on a recording the player can collect; the American ratings board described an audio file in which a female character is sexually assaulted by male characters, without visual depiction (TheSixthAxis, reporting the ESRB). Critics objected that the most notorious tape is unlocked as a reward for completing optional objectives. Ria Jenkins argued in *The Guardian* that the game fails to treat sexual violence meaningfully, and asked why the European ratings board had applied no comparable warning (The Guardian, 9 April 2014; Critical Distance). Defenders replied that the tapes are rewards only in the sense that every recovered tape advances the plot (Singh 2014). The dispute matters to this thesis because the cassette is Kojima's signature archive of the absent and the dead, from the recorded voice of The Boss in *Peace Walker* to the tapes through which Venom learns who he is. Here the archive holds an atrocity in collectible form, and the corpus's own ethic of custody supplies the verdict the game withholds: an archive that hands its listener a person's violation as an item to be found has confused custody with possession.



Part II

The Meme

Simulation, Context, and Control

Part II follows the corpus across the threshold Dawkins drew at the end of *The Selfish Gene*: from the replicator that is inherited to the replicator that is imitated, chosen, and transmitted. The passage promises emancipation — a self no longer written by its genome — and the two works read here discover what the promise conceals. If identity is memetic, it can be manufactured; if information is the new inheritance, whoever filters information governs inheritance. *Sons of Liberty* stages the manufacture of a hero by simulation; *Guns of the Patriots* stages a world governed by the dead through the code they left behind. Between them, the figure that will organize the rest of this thesis comes into view: the Dead Hand.



4

Selection for Societal Sanity

The Menardian Sequel and the Prophecy of Context

4.1 From Gene to Meme

In the eleventh chapter of *The Selfish Gene*, Dawkins proposed the meme as a unit of cultural transmission – a tune, an idea, a catchphrase, a fashion – replicating by imitation and subject to its own selection. Kojima names *meme* as the theme of *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (2001), and the game's central conceit is that "Solid Snake" is no longer a man but a meme: a role that can be learned, rehearsed, and reproduced. Its protagonist for most of its length is not Snake but Raiden, a rookie trained in virtual-reality simulations of the Shadow Moses incident, dispatched to an offshore facility in New York Bay where a structurally identical incident is unfolding. Midway through, the player learns of an initiative called the S3 Plan, presented at first as a Solid Snake Simulation – a program to manufacture another Snake – and revealed at last as Selection for Societal Sanity, a program for the control of information itself. The misdirection is the meme in action. The player's belief about what the game is doing was planted, and it propagated.

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) gives the cultural stakes. Aura, for Benjamin, is the unique presence of a thing in time and space, its embeddedness in a tradition; reproduction detaches the object from that tradition and multiplies it. Snake is the saga's aura; Raiden is its reproduction. The game's notorious reception – the outrage of players who discovered, after a marketing campaign that had concealed him, that they would spend most of the game as a blond, inexperienced substitute – was not an accident external to the work. It was the work's subject arriving on schedule. The player wanted to remain Snake, which is to say wanted the aura, and the game made that wish the ob-

ject of its critique. Brecht designed his *Verfremdungseffekt* to prevent the audience's identification with the hero so that it could judge the situation; *Sons of Liberty* is the rare mass entertainment that pursued the same goal against the explicit desire of its audience.

Japanese theory supplies a closer diagnosis than Benjamin's. Azuma Hiroki's *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals* (2001) argued that after the collapse of grand narratives, which Japanese social theory dates to the mid-1990s, otaku culture consumes not stories but databases of elements – traits, accessories, gestures – recombined into new characters. *Sons of Liberty*'s "Snake" is a database character: bandana, radio codec, cardboard box, a manner of crouching, all transferable to another body. Its in-world emblem is Otacon, whose name comes from "otaku convention" and who became an engineer, he says, because of the robots of Japanese animation. In Kojima the otaku's database is conscripted by the war machine: the fan who loved giant robots builds the nuclear-armed one. Azuma's account revises Ōtsuka's (0.2). Where Ōtsuka's consumers reconstruct a hidden world from fragments, Azuma's no longer need one. The *Metal Gear* public does both, and the S3 Plan is the institution that profits from the difference.

4.2 Menard's Shadow Moses

In Borges's "Pierre Menard, Author of the *Quixote*" (1939), a twentieth-century French symbolist sets out to compose passages of *Don Quixote* that coincide word for word with Cervantes – not by copying but by arriving at them – and the narrator argues that Menard's identical text is far richer than the original, because the same words written three centuries later, by a different man in a different world, mean something else entirely. The Big Shell is Menard's Shadow Moses. The Plant chapter repeats the structure of the first game almost beat for beat: an insertion by water, the rescue of hostages, a ninja who is ambiguously an ally, an unseen informant, a captivity in which the protagonist is stripped and strung up, an army of Metal Gears, and a final duel with a Snake. The repetition is explicit in the fiction, where the incident proves to have been staged as a re-creation of Shadow Moses for the purpose of conditioning Raiden into a Snake. The same events, re-situated, invert their meaning: what was heroism in 1998 is conditioning in 2001.

The Menardian structure is also a critique of the sequel as a cultural form. Every sequel is a simulation of its predecessor offered to an audience trained by that predecessor to desire it; every sequel is a Solid Snake Simulation. Kojima's achievement was to make the player experience the sequel's logic as a trap, and to make the trap the game's content. A principle emerges here that governs his entire corpus and will be invoked again in Chapter 10: Kojima's second installments are auto-critiques. *Sons of Liberty* interrogates the heroic myth of *Metal Gear Solid*; *Death Stranding 2* will interrogate the connective utopia of *Death Stranding*.

The game's release gave its finale a charge no design could have intended. *Sons of Liberty* reached North American shelves in November 2001, two months after the September 11 attacks, and it ends with a fortress-vessel driven aground in lower Manhattan, its last duel fought on the roof of Federal Hall. The coincidence belongs to reception rather than design, but it bound the game's account of manufactured context to the most heavily mediated event of its decade.

4.3 Simulacra and the Constructed Lifeworld

Baudrillard opened *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) with Borges's fable of the cartographers whose map grew to the size of the empire, and inverted it: in the era of simulation, the map precedes the territory and engenders it. The Big Shell crisis is such a map, a simulation that precedes and produces the reality its participants inhabit. Philip K. Dick's *Time Out of Joint* (1959) is its closest literary prototype. Dick's Ragle Gumm believes he lives in a small American town in the 1950s and spends his days winning a newspaper puzzle contest; in fact the town has been constructed around him so that his solutions, which predict enemy missile strikes, can be harvested by the state without his knowledge. *The Truman Show* (1998) and *The Matrix* (1999) brought the conceit to the cinema in the years immediately preceding *Sons of Liberty*. Kojima's distinctive contribution is to include the player in the constructed world: the medium itself is the simulated town.

The game's metalepses — in Genette's sense (1972), transgressions of the boundary between narrative levels — enforce this inclusion. As the fiction's command structure disintegrates, Raiden's commanding officer begins to speak nonsense, at one point ordering him to turn off the game console; a counterfeit game-over screen announces, by spoonerism, that the mission has been "failed" in reverse; the dog tags Raiden carries bear the name and particulars the player entered at the start. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921) had staged characters aware of their authorship, and Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* (1979) had made the second-person reader its protagonist. *Sons of Liberty* fuses the two devices in a medium where the second person is not a rhetorical figure but a body holding a controller.

Lacan's psychoanalysis supplies the structure of the revelation. The commanding voice on Raiden's radio, the Colonel, is the big Other — the guarantor of the symbolic order, the one presumed to know. He turns out to be an artificial intelligence. Lacan's dictum that there is no Other of the Other, and that the big Other does not exist, here takes the form of a plot twist: the authority behind the authority is a program. Yet, as Žižek (1989) insisted, the nonexistence of the big Other does not diminish its efficacy, because ideology operates in what we do, not in what we believe. *Sons of Liberty* further claims that the Patriots' founding committee had been dead for a century, leaving their system to govern in their absence — a claim its sequel will re-

vise. A law without a living lawgiver, administered by guardians who may not know its source, is Kafka's "Before the Law" (1915), and it is the first appearance in the corpus of the Dead Hand.

4.4 La-Li-Lu-Le-Lo: The Unspeakable Name

The characters of *Sons of Liberty* cannot say the Patriots' name. In its place they utter a string of syllables, la-li-lu-le-lo, and *Guns of the Patriots* later explains that the nanomachines in their bodies prevent the word from being spoken. The device condenses three structures. The first is the Tetragrammaton, the divine name that observant Judaism does not pronounce, substituting a title in its place: the Patriots' name is ineffable in the manner of a god's. The second is the taboo on the names of the dead, which Freud examined in the second essay of *Totem and Taboo*: among many peoples, to speak the name of the dead is to summon them, and the name is therefore forbidden or replaced. The Patriots – founders believed dead – have exactly such a name. The third is Lacan's *Nom-du-Père*, homophonous in French with the *Non-du-Père*: the Name of the Father that institutes the symbolic law is also the Father's prohibition, effective precisely in its absence. The Patriots are the Name-of-the-Father implemented as a censorship protocol.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok's analysis of cryptonymy (1976) – words that conceal other words, sheltering a forbidden utterance in a psychic crypt – names the device's form. La-li-lu-le-lo is a cryptonym. Its choice is not arbitrary. The syllables correspond to the row of the Japanese syllabary that renders both the English *l* and the English *r*, the conflation of which is a stock marker, in Anglophone caricature, of the Japanese speaker's difficulty with English. The unspeakable name of power is thus spelled in the phonemes that mark the border between Japanese and English. It is a joke, and it is a prophecy: the politics of language that *The Phantom Pain* will make explicit is already encrypted in the Patriots' censored name.

4.5 The Colonel's Discourse: A Pharmacology of Information

The most celebrated passage in the game is the artificial intelligence's account of its own purpose, delivered to Raiden near the end. Its argument, in paraphrase, runs as follows. The digital society amplifies human weaknesses and rewards the convenient half-truth. Freed from any shared filter, individuals retreat into small communities of agreement; truth fragments into private versions; the flood of trivial information drowns what matters. The Patriots therefore do not intend to suppress content. They intend to create *context* – to curate relevance on behalf of a humanity that can no longer do so for itself.

The discourse has been widely praised for its prescience, and the praise is deserved: Cass Sunstein's *Republic.com*, which warned of digital echo chambers, ap-

peared in the same year, and the vocabulary of filter bubbles (Pariser 2011) and post-truth arrived a decade and more later. But prescience is the least interesting thing about it. The AI's argument has a genealogy. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the god Theuth presents writing as a remedy for memory, and King Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness and the appearance of wisdom without its substance. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the word Plato uses, *pharmakon*, means both remedy and poison, undecidably. The AI's "context" is a pharmakon: a cure for informational chaos that is also the poison of autonomy. Neil Postman's *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985) contrasted Orwell's fear that information would be withheld with Huxley's fear that we would be given so much that we would be reduced to passivity and egoism. The AI's diagnosis is Huxleyan and its prescription Orwellian; it proposes to cure Huxley with Orwell.

Its truest ancestor, however, is the Grand Inquisitor of Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), who explains to a returned Christ that human beings cannot bear the freedom he offered them, and that the Church, out of love, has relieved them of it with miracle, mystery, and authority. The Patriots' AI is the Grand Inquisitor of the information age, and the decisive interpretive question is how the game answers it. In Dostoevsky, Christ makes no reply; he kisses the old man. Raiden makes no refutation either. The game's answer comes afterward, from Snake, and it is not a counter-argument but an injunction: that each person must decide what to believe and what to pass on. The answer to the Inquisitor is a gesture, not a doctrine. Kojima's response to the problem of information is not epistemological but ethical – not a better filter, but the individual act of selecting and transmitting a meme. This answer will be tested in every subsequent work, and the test will become, in *Death Stranding*, the whole of the game.

4.6 Solid, Liquid, Solidus: The Phase Diagram of Modernity

The names of the three clones form a vocabulary that has gone unremarked. In metallurgy and materials science, the *solidus* is the curve on a phase diagram below which an alloy is entirely solid, the *liquidus* the curve above which it is entirely liquid; between them lies a zone in which solid and liquid coexist. Solid, Liquid, and Solidus are therefore not merely three states but a phase diagram, and Solidus is its boundary condition.

Read historically, the diagram is the diagram of modernity. Marx and Engels wrote in 1848 that "all that is solid melts into air," and Marshall Berman (1982) made the phrase the title of an account of modernity as perpetual dissolution. Zygmunt Bauman's *Liquid Modernity* (2000) described the present as an age in which the solids of earlier modernity – stable bonds, institutions, identities – have melted into flows. Liquid Snake, the stateless mercenary and terrorist, is the avatar of liquefaction; Solid Snake, bound by loyalty and mission, is the residue of solid modernity;

Solidus, who leads an insurrection named for the American revolutionaries of 1765 and fights his last battle on the roof of Federal Hall, where Washington took the oath of office in 1789, is the sovereign attempting to re-solidify the state at the very temperature at which it melts.

Solidus is also the corpus's most explicit Kronos. The liberator of the nation is revealed to have conscripted children into a civil war in Liberia. Raiden was one of them. By the game's own revelation, Solidus killed his parents, named him Jack, and raised him as a child soldier in the Liberian civil war from as young as six; his kill count earned him the names Jack the Ripper and White Devil. The founding father who devours his sons is the image Goya painted on the wall of his house in the 1820s, and its presence here is not decorative. The rhetoric of founding liberty is spoken by a man who fed children to war, and the game refuses to separate the two. Revolver Ocelot, meanwhile, inhabits the mushy zone between the phases. A double and triple agent, he carries Liquid's transplanted arm and, apparently, Liquid's possessing personality; by *Guns of the Patriots* he will have become Liquid Ocelot, an identity produced by graft and self-hypnosis. The liquid is not a state he passes through; it is something grafted into him.

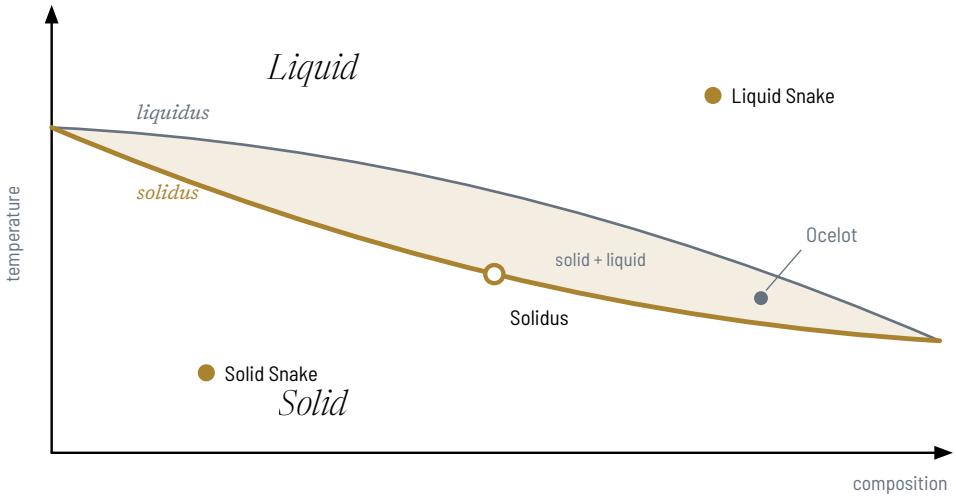


Figure 4.1 *A phase diagram of modernity. Liquid lies above the liquidus and Solid below the solidus; Solidus stands on the boundary itself, Ocelot in the zone where both phases coexist.*

4.7 Raiden's Nakedness and the Exit from Interpellation

Captured aboard Arsenal Gear, Raiden is stripped and must cross the ship naked, covering himself as he goes. The sequence is comic, and its comedy is the comedy of a profound reduction. Nakedness is the zero degree of the soldier, whose identity is

his equipment. It recalls Adam, who discovers his nakedness at the moment of knowledge, and it anticipates the Naked Snake of *Snake Eater*, released three years later and set forty years earlier. Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) distinguished *zoē*, bare biological life, from *bios*, qualified political life, and found in the modern sovereign's power over bare life the hidden paradigm of politics. Raiden naked is bare life with a sword: the subject stripped of every symbolic investiture except the one he will choose.

The game ends with a choice of that kind. Raiden discards his dog tags — the tags inscribed with the player's own name. Althusser's account of ideology (1970) turns on interpellation: ideology hails individuals as subjects, as a policeman hails a passerby, and in turning toward the call the individual becomes the subject it names. The dog tags are the game's hail, the inscription of the player into the role. In throwing them away, Raiden releases himself from the player and the player from the game: the avatar ends the interpellation that made him an avatar. The meme is released from its host. It is an exit, not a solution — an exit the saga will need two more games to make good.

The exit has a hostage at its threshold. The Patriots compel Raiden to kill Solidus with the lives of Rose, the unborn child she is carrying, and Olga Gurlukovich's infant daughter held as stakes, and the game ends with Raiden and Rose reunited and their child still to come (Metal Gear Wiki; TheGamer). Two arguments follow. Deterrence's grammar of the hostage (Chapter 12) is here applied not to cities but to the unborn, so that the S3 Plan governs by holding the future itself at gunpoint. And the first unborn child to stand at the end of a Kojima game appears exactly where the meme is released. At the moment the hero throws away the inscription that made him a copy, natality enters as the form of a future that is not a repetition. *Death Stranding* will strap that figure to the porter's chest.

5

The Dead Hand

Mortmain, the War Economy, and the Society of Control

5.1 War Has Changed

Metal Gear Solid 4: Guns of the Patriots (2008) opens on a proposition it repeats as a refrain: war has changed. In the fiction's 2014, war is no longer waged for nations, ideologies, or ethnicities; it is an endless series of proxy conflicts fought by private military companies, whose operations sustain a global war economy on which the world's prosperity now depends. Kojima's theme word is *sense*, and the game's sense is that war has ceased to be an event and become an environment.

The proposition stands at the end of a lineage of inversions. Clausewitz's *On War* (1832) defined war as the continuation of politics by other means. Foucault, in the lectures published as "Society Must Be Defended" (1976), inverted the formula: politics is the continuation of war by other means, the codification of a struggle that never ended. *Guns of the Patriots* performs a third inversion: the economy is the continuation of war, and war the substance of the economy. Eisenhower's farewell address (1961) had warned of the military-industrial complex; P. W. Singer's *Corporate Warriors* (2003) documented the privatization of military force after the Cold War; Naomi Klein's *The Shock Doctrine* (2007), published the year before the game, described a capitalism that feeds on catastrophe. Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) had argued that every society must expend a surplus it cannot productively absorb, and that war is the most catastrophic form of that expenditure. The war economy of *Guns of the Patriots* is Bataille's accursed share made permanent and profitable: expenditure administered as a utility.

Ernst Jünger's "Total Mobilization" (1930) described the conversion of the whole of social life into a reservoir of energy for war; Paul Virilio (1977; 1984) described war's dependence on logistics and on the technologies of perception that render the battlefield visible. In Kojima's 2014, total mobilization proceeds by contract, and the logistics of perception have been installed inside the soldier's body.

5.2 SOP: The Society of Control Made Flesh

The instrument of that installation is the Sons of the Patriots system. Nanomachines in every contracted soldier monitor vital signs, share battlefield data, suppress pain and fear, and regulate emotion in the interest of performance; every firearm is registered to an authorized user and will not fire in other hands, so that the arms trade survives only through launderers who unlock them. When Liquid Ocelot seizes the system and withdraws its regulation, the suppressed affects return at once, and soldiers across the battlefield collapse under a flood of fear and pain held back for years.

Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) is the theory of this apparatus. The disciplinary societies Foucault described operated through enclosures – school, barracks, factory, prison – that molded individuals; societies of control operate through continuous modulation, in which codes and passwords replace signatures, the corporation replaces the factory, and the individual becomes a "dividual," a divisible bundle of data. The SOP soldier is a dividual. His fear is a parameter; his weapon reads a password; his body is an endpoint on a network administered by a power that never appears. Agamben's public refusal of biometric entry procedures (2004), which he condemned as the extension to citizens of identification techniques once reserved for criminals and the interned, reads in this light as a refusal of the SOP in its embryonic form.

The collapse that follows the system's suspension is the return of the repressed at planetary scale, and the game lodges its testimony in four women. Each member of the Beauty and the Beast Unit was made by an atrocity in childhood, and in each case the atrocity took the form of a killing she was forced into or could not prevent. Laughing Octopus, whose village was attacked by a sect that despised its custom of eating octopus, was made to kill her own family, laughing as she did so. Raging Raven, born in Aceh, a province long at war, killed every living person in a camp, soldiers and captive civilians alike. Crying Wolf, a refugee from ethnic cleansing, smothered her brother while trying to silence his crying as they hid from a soldier, and the game implies that she later silenced the infants of a refugee camp in the same way. Screaming Mantis, born amid war in a South American village, learned to shut out the screams around her and was then subjected to gene therapy and nanomachine experiments under Liquid Ocelot, who used her control over the others' nanomachines to hold the unit together (Giant Bomb). Their armor is a compilation

as well as a wound: their names derive from *Metal Gear Solid*'s FOXHOUND, their weapons from *Sons of Liberty*'s Dead Cell, their emotions from *Snake Eater*'s Cobras. The saga's earlier bosses are compiled into four bodies, as if the series had become a war economy feeding on its own archive.

Defeated, each emerges from her armor and moves toward Snake for an embrace whose touch, in the game's mechanics, can burn him, and her history is narrated afterward by the gun launderer Drebin: the testimony of war's victims is ventriloquized by its merchant. Crying Wolf's history is the dark counterpart of Quiet's (Chapter 6). Quiet's silence is chosen to protect others; Wolf's hand over a child's mouth, meant to protect him, killed him – the corpus's starkest image of the hand that shelters and destroys in a single gesture (Chapter 9). Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) argued that pain resists language, that it is the least shareable of experiences, and that war is structured as a contest in injuring that converts bodies into evidence for political claims. The SOP abolishes the body's testimony by abolishing its pain. The Beauty and the Beast Unit is that testimony returning in the only form left to it, as monstrosity.

5.3 Mount Rushmore in the Machine

The Patriots, *Guns of the Patriots* reveals, are a network of artificial intelligences: a central core designated JD and four subordinate systems, GW, TJ, AL, and TR. The initials are those of George Washington, Thomas Jefferson, Abraham Lincoln, and Theodore Roosevelt – the four presidents whose faces were carved between 1927 and 1941 into Mount Rushmore. The core's designation, John Doe, is the name given to a man without a name. The Patriots' architecture is a digital Rushmore with an anonymous fifth face at its center: sovereignty as the effigies of the founders, administered by no one.

The monument's history completes the figure. Rushmore is carved into the Black Hills, Paha Sapa, sacred to the Lakota and guaranteed to the Sioux by the Fort Laramie Treaty of 1868, then seized by the United States, by act of Congress in 1877, after an army expedition under George Armstrong Custer reported gold there in 1874. In *United States v. Sioux Nation of Indians* (1980) the Supreme Court recognized the taking and awarded compensation, which the Lakota have refused, demanding the land itself. The faces of the fathers are carved into expropriated ground. The Patriots inherit that structure: the governance of the living by the effigies of the dead, erected on a dispossession the effigies do not acknowledge. Part III will find, in *The Phantom Pain*'s Navajo scientist Code Talker, the dispossessed who stand beneath the monument.

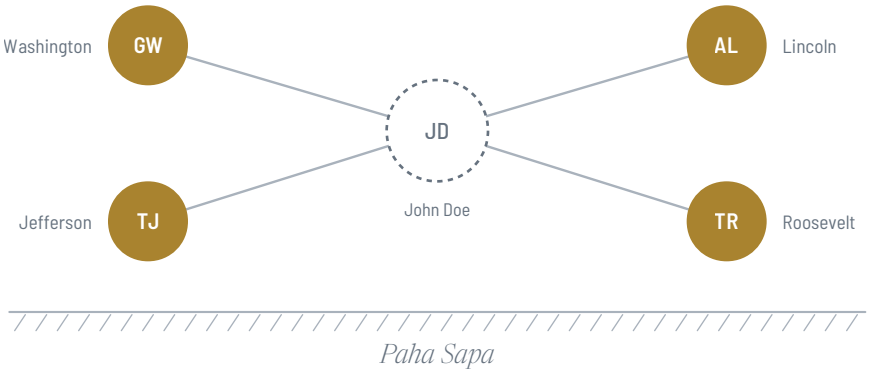


Figure 5.1 *A digital Rushmore. Four founders' initials around an anonymous core, administering a world from ground they did not own.*

5.4 Usufruct and Mortmain

On 6 September 1789, writing from Paris to James Madison, Jefferson proposed as self-evident "that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living" and that "the dead have neither powers nor rights over it." Usufruct, in Roman law, is the right to use and enjoy the fruits of a property without impairing its substance; Jefferson's point was that no generation may bind its successors, so that laws, constitutions, and debts should expire with the generation that contracted them. Two years later, in *Rights of Man* (1791), Thomas Paine condemned "the vanity and presumption of governing beyond the grave" as the most ridiculous and insolent of tyrannies.

The opposite principle has a legal name. Mortmain, the "dead hand," designated land held in perpetuity by ecclesiastical corporations, which never died and therefore never relinquished what they held; the Statute of Mortmain of 1279 restricted the practice because it removed land from the cycle of inheritance. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) traced the juridical fiction that made such perpetuity thinkable: a body politic that never dies, distinct from every mortal body that temporarily bears it.

The Patriots are mortmain. They are a corporation of the dead holding the world in perpetuity, governing according to the design of absent founders, and they administer this dominion through a system that bears the initials of the very man who declared the earth the usufruct of the living. Adam Smith's invisible hand – the order that emerges from interactions no one directs – has become, in the war economy, a dead hand: an autonomous system executing the will of the deceased. Freud's dead father, stronger in death than in life, is here not a myth of origins but an operating system.

The game's resolution is accordingly an act against mortmain. Its last revelations show that Major Zero, founder of the Patriots, survives in a vegetative state sustained by machines – a sovereign neither living nor dead, the dead hand made flesh. Big Boss, the other founder, has also survived, and his final act is to end Zero's life: to lift the dead hand from the world. He then dies himself, of the virus carried in his son's blood, at The Boss's grave, beside the son he never raised. In his last words he reinterprets his teacher's will. Neither he nor Zero, he concedes, had understood it: The Boss had not wanted the world unified under any control but left to be what it would become. Heidegger's late concept of *Gelassenheit*, releasement (1959) – a comportment that uses technical things while letting them be, and lets the world be – names this revised will with precision. The Patriots were *Gestell*, the enframing that "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) identified as the essence of technology, the ordering of everything as standing reserve. The Boss's will, in its final exegesis, was releasement.

5.5 Old Snake: Nostos, Passion, and the Refusal of Suicide

Solid Snake appears in *Guns of the Patriots* as an old man. The clones were engineered to age rapidly, and the hero's body has become a clock running out; Leonard Hayflick's discovery (1961) that somatic cells divide only a limited number of times supplies the biology the fiction exaggerates. The fourth act returns him to Shadow Moses, the site of the first *Metal Gear Solid*, now in ruins, where he pilots the derelict REX against its successor. This is a *nostos*, the epic hero's homecoming, and the home is a ruin. The word *nostalgia* – *nostos* and *algos*, the pain of return – was coined in 1688 by the Swiss physician Johannes Hofer to name the homesickness that afflicted, among others, Swiss soldiers serving abroad. Nostalgia entered medicine as a disease of mercenaries. *Guns of the Patriots*, a game about a world of mercenaries, is nostalgic in the clinical sense, and its old hero's return to his ruined origin is at once the illness and its diagnosis.

The fifth act contains the corpus's purest passion sequence. Snake crawls through a corridor of microwave emitters toward the system's core while his body burns, and the screen divides to show his companions fighting and falling elsewhere; the player must press a button repeatedly to keep him moving. The sequence is a Via Dolorosa rendered as input. It converts the player's hand into an instrument of compassion in the etymological sense – suffering-with. Scarry's insight that pain resists representation is answered by a medium that does not represent pain so much as distribute its labor between a body on the screen and a hand on the controller. The haptic ethics of *Death Stranding* begins in this corridor.

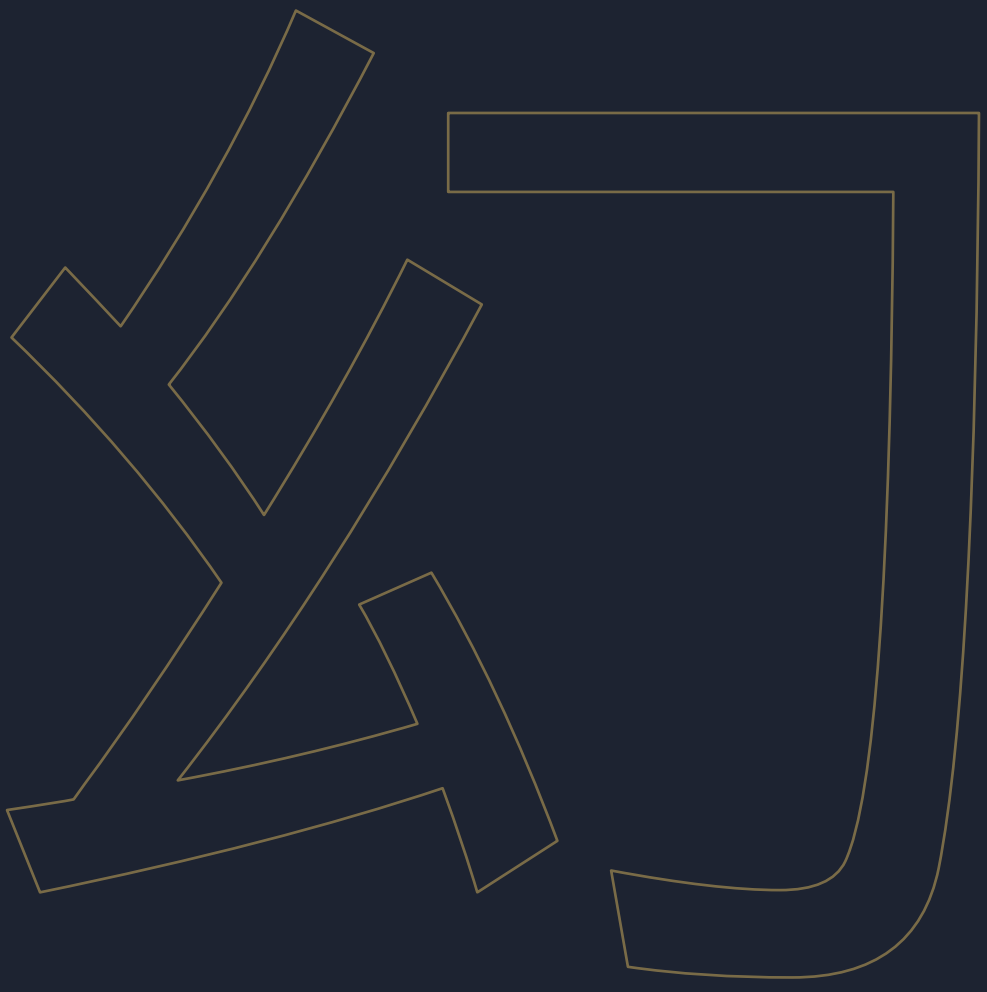
In the epilogue, alone at The Boss's grave, Snake prepares to take his own life and is interrupted by the arrival of the father he had twice killed. Camus opened *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) by declaring suicide the one truly serious philosophical

problem: the judgment whether life is worth living. Snake's answer, given to Otacon in the game's final moments, is to live out the time that remains and see what the world becomes — the absurd hero's revolt, chosen by a man whose remaining time is short. Big Boss's death completes a different cycle. In 1987 and 1990 the son killed the father. In 2008 the father dies beside the son, of a death the son did not inflict, sharing a cigar and declaring himself content. The parricide that founded the saga is not repeated; it is dissolved. If *Snake Eater* posed Nietzsche's riddle of the snake, this is the first bite. The ouroboros releases its tail.

5.6 The Dead Hand as Master Antagonist

The figure that organizes Part II can now be stated as a definition. The Dead Hand is any system through which the dead govern the living without their consent: the automatic retaliation that executes a dead commander's threat (Perimeter, Peace Walker); the corporation that holds in perpetuity (mortmain); the founders' effigies administering a nation (the Patriots); the economy that consumes lives by a logic no living person directs (the war economy); the father's law, stronger after his death (Freud); the genome whose engineered senescence executes a designer's plan inside a son's body. The corpus's heroes are those who return the earth to usufruct.

The distinction that will govern Part IV is already visible: between *resurrection*, in which the dead return to rule, and *repatriation*, in which the dead are returned to the dead so that the living may live. *Death Stranding* will make that distinction its metaphysics, and will mark the dead hand on the ground in prints.



Part III

The Phantom

Language, Revenge, and Mourning

Part III reads the works of 2014 and 2015, the years in which the corpus's thought of inheritance became a thought of loss. *The Phantom Pain* names its subject in its title: the pain of what is no longer there. Its losses are of tongues, limbs, homelands, and faces, and finally of the self, which proves to be a prosthesis worn in another's name. *P.T.*, released the same year as *Ground Zeroes* and withdrawn the year *The Phantom Pain* appeared, is a work about a ghost that became a ghost. Together they are the corpus's work of mourning, and they discover that mourning and inheritance are one act seen from opposite sides.

6

Parasitic Tongues

Language as Weapon, Homeland, and Symbiont

6.1 The Vocal Cord Parasite

Metal Gear Solid V: The Phantom Pain (2015) is set in 1984. Its antagonist, Skull Face, commander of the covert unit XOF, possesses a biological weapon of unusual design: a parasite that inhabits the human vocal cords, ancient and ordinarily benign, which can be engineered to activate when its host speaks a particular language, killing the speaker and spreading through speech. His target is English. His grievance, as he recounts it, is biographical: a childhood in a borderland overrun again and again, each occupier imposing its tongue, so that his words, and with them his self, were taken from him repeatedly. His plan, as he expounds it, couples the destruction of the world's lingua franca with the proliferation of nuclear deterrence through a walking weapon placed in many hands – a world of linguistically sovereign peoples, each holding the others hostage. Kojima publicly framed the game's themes as revenge and race, the latter glossed broadly as everything that divides people by language, culture, and nation.

6.2 The Genealogy of Linguistic Relativity

Skull Face's philosophy has a distinguished ancestry. Herder's *Treatise on the Origin of Language* (1772) bound language to the formation of peoples. Wilhelm von Humboldt (1836) argued that language is not a finished product (*ergon*) but an activity (*energeia*), and that each language embodies a distinct view of the world. Edward Sapir (1929) held that human beings live very much at the mercy of the language that has become the medium of expression for their society, and Benjamin Lee Whorf, in

essays collected posthumously in 1956, gave the thesis its strongest form. Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (1921) supplied its aphorism – "The limits of my language mean the limits of my world" (5.6) – and Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) its ontological consecration, in which language is the house of being.

Skull Face is a Herderian and Whorfian terrorist. If a language is a world, the death of a language is the death of a world, and a hegemonic language is a killer of worlds. The premise is not paranoid: linguists estimate that roughly half of the world's languages are endangered (Nettle and Romaine 2000), and the global expansion of English is among the forces implicated. Contemporary cognitive science has largely rejected strong linguistic determinism while finding real but bounded effects of language on cognition, for instance in spatial frames of reference (Levinson 2003). The game takes the strong thesis as its novum, in Suvin's sense, and pursues it to a genocidal conclusion: if the killer of worlds is a language, one may kill its speakers.

6.3 Babel Reversed

In Genesis 11 "the whole earth was of one language, and of one speech"; its people build a tower; the Lord confounds their language and scatters them. Skull Face proposes to destroy the one language so that the many may live, and in this he does not oppose the God of Babel but imitates Him. He is a Yahwist terrorist, re-enacting the confusion of tongues as judgment on an imperial tower. Derrida's "Des Tours de Babel" (1985) observed that *Babel* is at once a proper name – by one tradition the name of God the Father – and a common noun meaning confusion, so that the father's name imposes and forbids translation in a single gesture. Benjamin's "The Task of the Translator" (1923) imagined the plurality of languages as fragments of a broken vessel, whose intentions converge, through translation, toward a pure language that no single tongue contains.

Between the Patriots' single context (*Sons of Liberty*) and Skull Face's plurality by extermination, *The Phantom Pain* stages a third position, not in its rhetoric but in its rules. To interrogate enemy soldiers who speak Russian, Pashto, Afrikaans, or Kikongo, the player must recruit interpreters to Mother Base. The private army the player builds is, mechanically, a community of translators, drawn from the very battlefields it crosses. The game's procedural answer to Babel is Benjamin's: neither one language nor the killing of languages, but translation as a practice of the between.

6.4 Code Talker and the Colonial Archive

The game's authority on the parasites is an aged Navajo scientist known as Code Talker. His name recalls the Navajo code talkers of the Second World War, Marines whose language served as a battlefield code the enemy never broke – the same lan-

guage that United States federal boarding schools, which separated Native children from their families, had punished children for speaking, under the motto Richard Henry Pratt articulated in 1892: "Kill the Indian in him, and save the man." An indigenous language marked for eradication by the state became the state's unbreakable weapon. Code Talker embodies both moments of that history, and his presence anchors Skull Face's grievance in a history authored by the nation the player's avatar served. It completes the figure begun at Mount Rushmore: the founders' faces above, the dispossessed tongues below.

Code Talker's account makes the parasites ancient co-inhabitants of the human body, implicated in human development, and his treatment for an outbreak among Mother Base's soldiers enlists another microorganism, the bacterial genus *Wolbachia*, known for manipulating the reproduction of its hosts. The biology is fiction, but its frame is Lynn Margulis's theory of symbiogenesis (1967; 1998), according to which the eukaryotic cell arose from the merger of once-independent organisms, so that every human being is, at the cellular level, a colony. *The Phantom Pain* extends the frame to language. The vocal cord parasite literalizes the metaphor Dawkins proposed in "Viruses of the Mind" (1993), and William S. Burroughs before him, of the word as virus: speech is a symbiont that can become a pathogen.

Frantz Fanon wrote in *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) that to speak a language is to assume a world and to bear the weight of a civilization. Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's *Decolonising the Mind* (1986) described the colonial school as the place where the subjugation begun by the bullet was completed by the word, and announced his own abandonment of English for Gĩkũyũ. Benedict Anderson's *Imagined Communities* (1983) showed how print vernaculars made nations imaginable. Skull Face is a nationalist of tongues who has read Fanon and Ngũgĩ with the eyes of a bioweapons designer. The game neither endorses nor dismisses his reading; it treats his grievance as true and his conclusion as monstrous.

6.5 The Linguistic Weapon in Speculative Fiction

The language-weapon is a minor genre of speculative fiction, and *The Phantom Pain* is its most literal instance. Samuel R. Delany's *Babel-17* (1966) imagines a language engineered as a weapon: lacking a first-person pronoun, it reprograms those who learn it into saboteurs unable to recognize their own agency, and a poet must decode it. Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992) imagines a neurolinguistic virus rooted in Sumerian myth, in which the god Enki's counter-incantation shattered a primordial, viral universal tongue and so freed human minds — a mythology in which Babel is not punishment but liberation. Skull Face is Stephenson's Enki: he would break the universal language to free the world from it. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998), filmed by Denis Villeneuve as *Arrival* (2016), offers the benign inver-

sion: learning an alien language restructures the learner's experience of time, so that a language given is a world given.

Kojima's version differs from all three in where it locates the weapon. Delany's weapon is a grammar, Stephenson's a code, Chiang's a cognition. Kojima's is a body. The parasite lives in the organ of speech and kills at the moment of utterance, so that to speak one's language is to die of it. The game thereby extends the corpus's history of weapons (Chapter 2): FOXDIE selected its victims by what they are, the parasite by what they say.

6.6 Quiet: The Ethics of Withheld Speech

The sniper Quiet, a former assassin infected with the English strain, cannot speak the language without releasing it. She breathes and drinks through her skin and says nothing. Her silence is protective, an abstention undertaken for others. At the end of her story she breaks it, speaking English to summon help for Venom Snake in mortal danger, and, having spoken, disappears into the desert, so that no one will be exposed to what she carries.

The final proposition of the *Tractatus* — "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent" — states a logical limit. Quiet's silence is an ethical one: she can speak and does not, because her speech kills. She is the corpus's purest figure of language as pharmakon, and of love as the withholding of a gift that has become a poison. Like The End, she is a plant-soldier, nourished by light; like Psycho Mantis, she shows that the medium of communication is also the medium of harm. Her exit is a rope withheld: the strand she declines to extend because it would carry death.

The reading must be qualified, because the game's treatment of Quiet's body cuts against it. In September 2013, answering criticism of the character's reveal, Kojima wrote that he had conceived her as an antithesis to the excessively exposed women of earlier fighting games, and promised that once players learned the secret reason for her exposure they would "feel ashamed of your words & deeds"; he added that the online reaction was itself what the game was about (Kotaku; [Wikipedia](<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Quiet_(Metal_Gear)>)). The reason the game supplies, that she breathes through her skin, persuaded few critics, and it sits beside a camera that lingers on her body, a shower sequence, and an attempted sexual assault on her (CheatCC; GameRevolution; Looper). Stefanie Joosten, who modeled and performed the role, later called the outfit impractical and noted that many other options had been open (Kotaku). Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) described the woman of classical cinema as coded for "to-be-looked-at-ness," an image displayed for a gaze she does not return. Quiet fits that description with uncomfortable precision: a woman forbidden to speak and offered to be seen.

Two observations sharpen the critique. Kojima's message is itself a metalepsis of the kind Chapter 13 describes, the author reaching across the frame to pre-empt a

reading, as Psycho Mantis reached for the player's memory card. And the claim that the controversy was the game repeats *Sons of Liberty*'s absorption of its players' backlash against Raiden, with one difference. There the absorption was a critique, because the game had anticipated the backlash and made it its subject. Here it works as an alibi, folding the objection into the work so that the work need not answer it. The ethics of withheld speech is real in Quiet's story, but it coexists with a politics of imposed silence, and the corpus's thought of the between does not extend to the gaze it directs at her. Kojima's later statement that in *Death Stranding* he wished to avoid sexualized characters without a backstory (Looper) is the closest the corpus comes to conceding the point.

6.7 The Lingua Franca of the Medium

The irony of the game's position cannot be avoided, and the game does not avoid it. A Japanese author, working in an industry whose dominant market and working language is English, made a game about English as the killer of worlds, voiced in its English version by a Hollywood actor and in its Japanese version by the Japanese actor who had long played Snake. Kojima's corpus has always looked toward Hollywood, and its late works are cast with Western film actors. *Sons of Liberty* had already encrypted the politics of English pronunciation in the Patriots' forbidden name. *The Phantom Pain* makes that politics its subject, and in doing so turns its gaze upon its own grammar. The global videogame, with its shared control schemes, genres, and idioms, is itself a lingua franca, and its author is at once one of its most fluent speakers and one of its subjects.

7

The Man Who Sold the World

Phantom Limbs, Revenge, and the Legend as Prosthesis

7.1 Phantom Limbs: From Mitchell to Merleau-Ponty

The phantom limb entered medicine through war. The American physician Silas Weir Mitchell, treating amputees of the Civil War, gave the phenomenon its name in 1871: the persistent and often painful sensation of a limb no longer there. Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) made it a crux of philosophy. The phantom limb, he argued, is neither a memory nor a physiological error. It is the body schema's refusal of mutilation, the persistence of a practical field – a world still organized for an arm that could reach into it – in which the habitual body outlives the body of the present moment. V. S. Ramachandran's research in the 1990s (Ramachandran and Blakeslee 1998) gave the phenomenon a therapy, to which this chapter returns.

The Phantom Pain distributes amputation across its cast until it becomes a condition of the world. Venom Snake wakes from a nine-year coma without his left arm, replaced by a prosthesis. Kazuhira Miller has lost an arm and a leg to torture. The soldiers of Mother Base are stateless, their homeland a platform at sea; Skull Face has lost his language and his face; Code Talker has outlived his people's place in the world. The phantom limb is the corpus's figure for diaspora: the persistent ache of a homeland, a tongue, a body part, or a self that the world has removed and the schema has not.

7.2 Ahab and Ishmael

The game's prologue codenames its patient Ahab and gives the bandaged stranger who guides his escape the name Ishmael. During the escape a whale of fire breaches over the hospital and devours a helicopter. The Melvillean apparatus is explicit, and it is exact. Ahab lost his leg to the white whale, and in the hundred-and-eighth chapter of *Moby-Dick* (1851) he tells the ship's carpenter that he still feels it – "one distinct leg to the eye, yet two to the soul." Melville gave the most famous avenger in American literature a phantom limb, and Kojima gave his avenger Ahab's name.

Ahab's metaphysics, announced on the quarter-deck in chapter thirty-six, holds that all visible objects are pasteboard masks behind which an unknown agency lurks, and that the avenger must "strike through the mask!" *The Phantom Pain*'s final revelation turns the injunction against itself. The man the player has been is not Big Boss but a medic of the old Mother Base, rebuilt by surgery and by Ocelot's hypnotherapy, on a plan devised by Zero and accepted by Big Boss, to wear Big Boss's face and memories as a decoy, while the real Big Boss – Ishmael – escapes to build his nation elsewhere. Venom Snake *is* the pasteboard mask. To strike through him would be to find no hidden essence behind the face, only another man.

The tapes that disclose the plan add a further turn. Ocelot, who administered the hypnotherapy, also hypnotized himself, so that he too would believe the fiction he had installed until the time came to remember: the liar makes himself the first believer in his lie. The saga's two technologies of the self converge in him. The phantom Big Boss of *The Phantom Pain* and the Liquid Ocelot of *Guns of the Patriots* are one procedure run in opposite directions, a man made to be another and a man making himself another, and both are administered by the corpus's master of the in-between.

Moby-Dick's epilogue takes its epigraph from Job: "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee." Big Boss is Ishmael, the survivor who escapes to become the teller of his own legend; Venom is Ahab, who goes down with the ship. And the sinking is already written. The commander whom Solid Snake kills in Outer Heaven in *Metal Gear* (1987) is the phantom. The last *Metal Gear* Kojima made feeds into the first: the corpus closes as an ouroboros whose mouth is the founding game.

7.3 Nietzsche and the Spirit of Revenge

In the chapter of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* titled "On Redemption" (1883), Nietzsche diagnoses revenge as the will's ill will toward time and its "it was." The will cannot will backward; it cannot break time and time's covetousness; and its impotence before the past is the root of every punishment it invents. Redemption would consist in transforming every "it was" into a "thus I willed it."

The Phantom Pain is a sustained demonstration of the spirit of revenge and its failure. Miller builds a private army whose purpose is vengeance; Skull Face seeks revenge on a language; the boy Eli, the future Liquid Snake, seeks revenge on his father; Huey Emmerich's self-justifications are revenge disguised as grievance. The game measures its protagonist's conduct in a hidden quantity that players call demon points. As Venom commits atrocities, the shard of shrapnel lodged in his skull grows into a horn, and his body darkens with blood that does not wash away: ressentiment becomes physiology. When vengeance is finally achieved, it changes nothing. Skull Face, pinned beneath wreckage, is shot in the limbs by Venom Snake and Kazuhira Miller, who hold him responsible for the loss of their own, in a grotesque attempt to transfer their amputations to his body, and is then killed by Huey Emmerich. The pain remains. The "it was" cannot be shot.

The game's most harrowing sequence makes the point without rhetoric, and it begins as a procedure. When the parasite first spreads through Mother Base, the player must identify the infected by the one thing they share – a language, most often Kikongo – and quarantine every soldier who speaks it (Twinfinite). The commander is made to sort his own soldiers by tongue, enacting on his own base the selection Skull Face planned for the world. In Episode 43, "Shining Lights, Even in Death," a mutated strain breaks out on the quarantine platform; Code Talker warns that no one may leave, and Venom must kill his infected men while Huey protests over the radio. Many of them salute as he approaches. At moments he looks away as he fires. The last man, who seemed spared, proves to have been infected through his wounds and urges him to finish it, and Venom collapses among the dead (GamingBolt; GamingBolt; Gameswelt). The bodies are burned, and the scene that follows gives the private army its name, as the ashes of the dead are made into diamonds that the living will carry with them.

Revenge here has no object at all: the pathogen has no face to shoot, and the commander who built a home for the homeless becomes the executioner of his own. The Fulton balloon carried enemies home and made them comrades; the quarantine reverses the gesture, and home becomes the place where comrades must be put to death. Yet the episode ends in an act of carrying. The dead are neither abandoned nor avenged but borne, as stones, by the living – the corpus's first image of the porterage of the dead that *Death Stranding* will make into an entire economy. The phantom pain of the Diamond Dogs is born less from Skull Face's crimes than from this act, which no vengeance can answer and only custody can hold.

7.4 Freud, Abraham and Torok, and the Incorporated Phantom

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguishes the slow withdrawal of attachment from a lost object, which is mourning, from the identification with the lost object that characterizes melancholia, in which, in his phrase, the shadow of the ob-

ject falls upon the ego. Venom Snake is melancholia carried out as a medical procedure. A man is made to identify so completely with the commander he lost that he becomes him. The shadow of Big Boss does not fall upon the medic's ego; it replaces it.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined Freud's distinction into an opposition between introjection, the healthy assimilation of a loss, and incorporation, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and keeping it alive in a psychic crypt (1972). Their "Notes on the Phantom" (1975) went further: a phantom, in their sense, is the presence in one generation of a secret that belonged to another – a gap left in us by the unspoken secrets of others, haunting descendants who do not know what they carry. The *Metal Gear* saga is a transgenerational phantom in exactly this sense. Big Boss's secret, the existence of his double, haunts Solid Snake, who kills the phantom without knowing whom he has killed. The Patriots' cryptonym (Chapter 4) is a crypt-word; Venom is a crypt with a man inside it.

7.5 The Mirror Box and the Face of Another

Ramachandran's treatment for phantom pain is a mirror. The patient places the intact limb in a box beside a mirror so that its reflection appears where the missing limb would be; moving the intact limb produces the visual illusion that the phantom moves, and cramps that resisted every other treatment can relax. The reflection of what remains is used to animate what is lost.

The Phantom Pain is structured by mirrors. The medic first meets his reconstructed face in a mirror; in the final scene he regards himself in a mirror again, sees there the face of the legend, and shatters the glass. The procedure that made him is a mirror-box therapy administered to history: the image of the intact Big Boss is used to animate a phantom identity, so that the legend's body schema persists after its original has departed. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the formation of the ego through identification with a specular image that is always, in part, alien. Venom is the mirror stage institutionalized by an army, and his blow against the mirror is the most ambiguous gesture in the corpus – refusal of the image, or its final acceptance, or both at once.

Here an elective affinity crosses a genealogy. Abe Kōbō, whose short story supplies *Death Stranding*'s epigraph, published *The Face of Another* in 1964; Teshigahara Hiroshi filmed it in 1966. Its narrator, a scientist whose face was destroyed in a laboratory accident, fabricates a lifelike mask, becomes another man, and seduces his own wife in his new face, until the mask acquires an autonomy he cannot control. Identity, in Abe, is a prosthesis that can usurp its wearer. Whether or not Kojima had the novel in mind, Abe's oeuvre spans the corpus's turn: *The Face of Another* is the novel of *The Phantom Pain*, as "The Rope" is the story of *Death Stranding*. Benjamin's terms apply with new force. Venom is Big Boss in the age of his technical re-

producibility, and the game's discovery is that aura survives reproduction by migrating: the legend now resides wherever its face is worn.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) made the face the site of ethics: the face of the other, prior to any knowledge of it, expresses a command, and its first meaning is the prohibition of murder. Venom Snake's face is borrowed, and the borrowing inverts Levinas. The face that should forbid killing becomes the mask in which a man kills in another's name, and the legend's face, multiplied across an army, commands not restraint but obedience. *Death Stranding*'s porter, who fears touch and must learn it, reverses the inversion: there the hand, not the face, carries the ethical demand.

The game's hermeneutic key is a song. David Bowie's "The Man Who Sold the World" (1970), heard in the game in Midge Ure's cover of 1982, turns on an uncanny meeting with a double who, the speaker learns, was thought to have died long ago. The song is itself a phantom of reproduction, passed among voices across decades. Its conceit is the game's plot compressed into a single encounter on a stair.

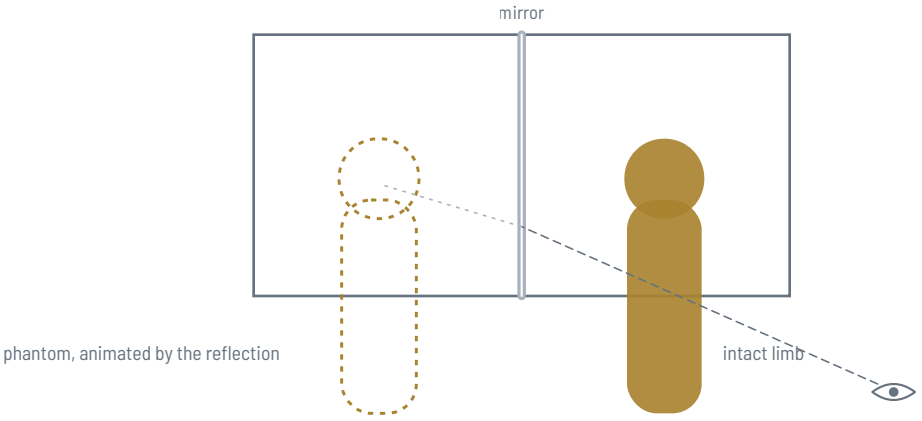


Figure 7.1 *The mirror box. The reflection of what remains is used to animate what is lost.*

7.6 The Amputated Work

The Phantom Pain is incomplete, and its incompleteness belongs to its meaning. Its second chapter ends abruptly. A planned episode, "Kingdom of the Flies," in which the young Liquid's army of children seizes the walking weapon on an island, survives only as unfinished footage on a bonus disc. The game was completed amid Kojima's separation from Konami, and players have felt the absence as a pain where a limb should be. The work about phantom pain has a phantom chapter. William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954), whose title translates the name of Beelzebub and whose stranded boys descend into ritual killing, is the missing episode's evident source; the episode's absence is its most eloquent form.

The year 2015 was, for this corpus, the year of phantoms. Konami cancelled *Silent Hills* and withdrew *P.T.*; it removed the studio's emblem from *The Phantom Pain*'s packaging while every mission still opened with its author's name; and in December it barred Kojima from attending The Game Awards, where Kiefer Sutherland, the English voice of Venom Snake, accepted the game's award in his place. The phantom stood in for the author. Barthes's death of the author (1967) was a theory; here it was an event, and its effects were precisely those the game had predicted for Big Boss. The name persisted, detached from its bearer, worn by a work its bearer could no longer finish.

7.7 Forward Operating Bases: Deterrence as a Multiplayer System

The Phantom Pain contains Kojima's first large-scale experiment in networked play, and it is an experiment in deterrence. Players build Forward Operating Bases online, which others may infiltrate to steal resources and personnel; they may also develop nuclear weapons, which reward their holders and discourage invaders. The game conceals an ending, a short sequence celebrating nuclear disarmament, that is triggered only when the total number of nuclear weapons held by every player on a given platform falls to zero. Because players can steal and dismantle one another's weapons, the condition requires both voluntary renunciation and coercive enforcement across an entire population.

The history of the condition is itself a document. Konami confirmed it in November 2015. A triggering on PC in February 2018 was acknowledged as a false positive caused by incorrect server values. The condition was reported met on the PlayStation 3 on 27 July 2020, nearly five years after release, by a population small enough to coordinate; the publisher's Japanese account said it was examining whether the result had been reached illegitimately, and new warheads were built within the day (Siliconera; DualShockers; Metal Gear Informer). Disarmament was achieved where the world had shrunk, contested as soon as it arrived, and reversed almost at once. As a parable of the nuclear age, it requires no commentary.

The apparatus is game-theoretically sophisticated. Each player faces a version of the prisoner's dilemma: disarmament is collectively optimal and individually exploitable. The weapons pose a commons problem in Garrett Hardin's sense (1968), and the only route to the hidden ending runs through what Elinor Ostrom (1990) called the governance of the commons, in which communities sustain shared goods through norms, monitoring, and sanctions rather than through private property or central command. The design makes disarmament the one ending no individual can reach alone. In that exact sense the deterrence economy of *The Phantom Pain* already contains, as its secret and nearly unreachable telos, the community of *Death Stranding*. Chapter 12 develops the comparison.

8

The Loop

P.T., Repetition Compulsion, and the Hauntological Artifact

8.1 The Corridor

In August 2014 a free download appeared on the PlayStation Network under the name of a studio that did not exist. *P.T.* – "playable teaser" – placed its player, in the first person, in a suburban L-shaped corridor: a hallway, a turn, a door at the end that returns the player to the start of the same hallway, altered. A radio narrates a father's murder of his wife and children. A woman's ghost haunts the passage. Solving the loop's final puzzle revealed the work's identity as a teaser for *Silent Hills*, to be directed by Kojima with Guillermo del Toro and to star Norman Reedus.

The form is the content. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) turned on repetitions that serve no pleasure – the traumatic dreams of soldiers returning to the scene of their injury, and the game of an eighteen-month-old who throws a spool away with a sound Freud heard as *fort*, "gone," and draws it back with *da*, "there," repeating in play the departure of his mother that he could not prevent in life. Psychoanalysis's founding theory of the death drive begins with a game of loss and return. *P.T.* is a *fort-da* corridor that masters nothing: each loop departs and returns, and each return is worse.

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) traced the German *unheimlich* to its root in *Heim*, home: the uncanny is the familiar estranged, the homely become unhomely, and among its sources is involuntary repetition. *P.T.* is the videogame's canonical uncanny because its space is a home that repeats. Its crime, meanwhile, is the corpus's most terrible version of the father – no longer the commander who betrays his sons on a distant battlefield but the man who kills his family in their house. Kronos has come home.

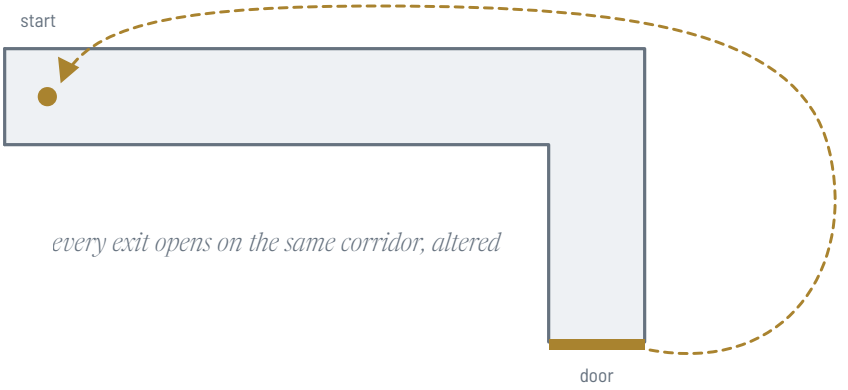


Figure 8.1 *The L-shaped corridor of P.T. Every exit returns the player to its entrance.*

8.2 Spiral, Labyrinth, House

The corridor belongs to a lineage of impossible interiors. Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000) concerns a house larger inside than out, in which a hallway appears where none should be and grows. Ito Junji's *Uzumaki* (1998–99) imagines a town infected by the spiral, a form that consumes those who fixate on it. Kafka's "A Little Fable," written around 1920, tells of a mouse whose world, once frighteningly wide, narrows into converging walls that end in a trap, and who is told by the cat, too late, that it need only have changed direction. Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980) set a father's attempted familicide in the corridors of a hotel whose final image reveals that he has always been there. Borges's "The House of Asterion" (1947) is narrated by the Minotaur from his labyrinth of endless galleries; he awaits a redeemer, and barely resists when Theseus arrives. *P.T.* fuses these: the impossible hallway, the contagious spiral, the narrowing trap, the familicidal father, the inhabitant of the labyrinth awaiting release. Its architecture is the ouroboros built in drywall.

8.3 The Fetus in the Sink

Among the corridor's horrors is a fetus that appears in a bathroom sink and cries. It is the most important image in *P.T.* for this thesis, because it belongs to a series. Les Enfants Terribles began with embryos carried by a surrogate; *P.T.* places an unborn child in a drain; *Death Stranding* straps unborn children in artificial wombs to the chests of couriers; its sequel turns on the fate of one of them. The unborn is the corpus's most persistent figure of the between – neither absent nor present, neither living in the full sense nor dead. In *P.T.* it appears as the abject in Kristeva's sense (1980), life in the drain, the boundary of the body breached, and as the uncanny

double of the children the radio's father murdered. The same figure becomes, five years later, the object of the corpus's tenderest care. What separates *P.T.* from *Death Stranding* is not the figure but the hand that holds it.

8.4 Collective Exegesis

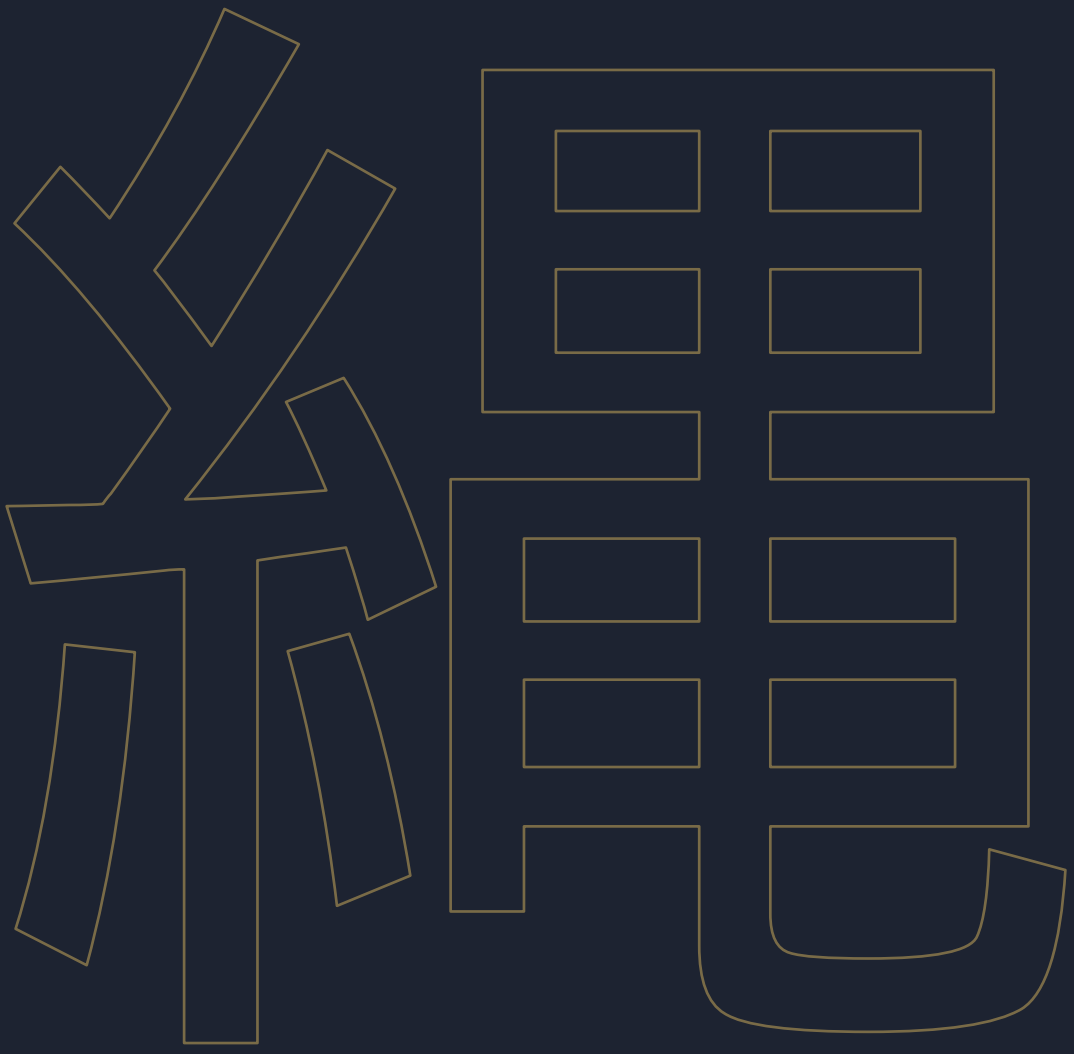
P.T.'s final puzzle was so opaque, and so dependent on conditions the game never explained, that it was solved collectively by players pooling observations across the internet. Pierre Lévy's *Collective Intelligence* (1994) had imagined networked publics assembling knowledge no individual possesses; Henry Jenkins's *Convergence Culture* (2006) found such knowledge communities forming around transmedia fictions. *P.T.* made collective interpretation a precondition of completion. It was the first Kojima work that could not, in practice, be finished alone, and in that sense it is the first strand: isolated players, each in a separate corridor, connected only by the shared labor of decoding.

8.5 The Delisted Ghost

In 2015 Konami cancelled *Silent Hills* and withdrew *P.T.* from sale. Once deleted from a console it could not be downloaded again; fan reconstructions were taken down after Konami intervened; consoles on which it remained installed acquired value as relics. A game about a ghost became a ghost.

The afterlife of the work has been policed. In July 2018 Konami had a seventeen-year-old developer take down his near-complete reconstruction of *P.T.* in Unreal Engine 4, citing legal issues while, by the developer's account, offering him an internship (Anime News Network; PCGamesN). Another fan reconstruction appeared that November (Gamewave). The ghost, exorcised from one body, takes up residence in another. The logic of the specter outruns the logic of property, and the institution that banished the work offered a position to its medium.

Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) named "hauntology" the logic of the specter, which is neither present nor absent, neither living nor dead, and which returns. Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014), drawing on Franco Berardi, extended the concept to the lost futures of a culture in which the future has been slowly cancelled. *P.T.* is a hauntological artifact in both senses: a work whose future — the game it announced — was cancelled, and which survives only as the revenant of that future on particular hard drives. Benjamin's aura, dissolved by reproduction, returns here through scarcity: each surviving installation is located, irreproducible, an original again. The work enacts its theme as an institutional fact. Within the arc of the corpus it is the threshold of the Beach. The first work Kojima made after leaving the company that withdrew *P.T.* opens on a shore strewn with the stranded dead.



Part IV

The Strand

Connection, Custody, Extinction

Part IV reads the *Death Stranding* diptych. The first game builds an ontology of connection in which every bond is also a commerce with the dead, and in which the carrying of cargo, corpses, and an unborn child becomes the substance of play. The second turns on its predecessor with a question. Together they complete the corpus's movement from the stick to the rope, and discover that the rope, too, can bind.



9

The Stick and the Rope

The Ontology of Connection in Death Stranding

9.1 Abe's Rope and Le Guin's Bag

Death Stranding (2019) opens with an epigraph from Abe Kōbō's short story "Nawa" ("The Rope"): the stick and the rope as humanity's oldest tools and first companions, the one for keeping bad things away, the other for drawing good things near. Kojima has glossed the epigraph as a description of the game itself: where most action games are games of the stick, this would be a game of the rope.

Feminist anthropology and fiction had reached the same opposition by another road. Elizabeth Fisher's *Woman's Creation* (1979) proposed that the first cultural device was probably not a weapon but a container – a sling, a net, a bag for gathered food. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) drew a poetics from the hypothesis. The heroic narrative, she argued, is the story of the spear, the killer story told around the mammoth, and it has crowded out the far longer story of gathering and carrying; she proposed fiction as a carrier bag, a medicine bundle holding things in particular and powerful relation to one another. *Death Stranding* is the carrier-bag epic that Le Guin's essay describes and that blockbuster media had not produced. Its hero is a porter, Sam Porter Bridges; its plot is a sequence of deliveries; its world accumulates rather than climaxes. No influence links Kojima to Le Guin. The convergence is an elective affinity, and its force lies in the independence of the paths that reached it.

Yet the opposition is not a replacement. *Death Stranding* arms its porter: with the Strand, a cord for binding human assailants; with non-lethal and, in time, lethal weapons; with grenades made from his own blood. The rope binds as well as con-

nects, and the stick survives in the carrier's kit. Kojima does not oppose the two tools so much as fold them, which is this thesis's claim about their chirality.

9.2 Homo Ludens, Homo Demens, Homo Portans

Kojima Productions' emblem is a figure in a spacesuit named Ludens, after Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938), which argued that play is older than culture and that culture arises in and as play, within a magic circle set apart from ordinary life. *Death Stranding*'s separatist terrorists call themselves Homo Demens, a term with its own genealogy: Edgar Morin's *Le Paradigme perdu* (1973) defined the human as *Homo sapiens demens*, the species in which rationality and delirium are inseparable. Between the player (*ludens*) and the destroyer (*demens*), the game proposes a third figure, which this thesis names *Homo portans*: the carrying human.

The figure has a paleoanthropology. C. Owen Lovejoy's "The Origin of Man" (1981) proposed that bipedalism evolved because it freed the hands to carry – provisions to mates and offspring – making provisioning a motor of hominization. André Leroi-Gourhan's *Gesture and Speech* (1964–65) argued that upright posture freed the hand for tools and the face for language, so that technics and speech co-evolved from a single anatomical event. Read through Leroi-Gourhan, the two Kojima works of the 2010s divide the inheritance of bipedalism between them. *The Phantom Pain* is a game of the face and of speech: its catastrophe lives in the vocal cords, and its protagonist's face is borrowed. Its mechanical antagonist is Sahelanthropus, named for *Sahelanthropus tchadensis*, among the oldest known hominins and a candidate for the first upright walker – a weapon that learns to stand. *Death Stranding* is a game of the hand and of gesture: its protagonist walks upright under a load, his hands freed to carry. The bipedal weapon and the bipedal porter are the two destinies of the upright animal, and Kojima wrote them one after the other.

The game's labor is walking – balance, weight, terrain, center of gravity – and its dismissive critical label, "walking simulator," forgets that walking is the primal human act (Solnit 2000). Tim Ingold's *Lines* (2007) supplies a sharper instrument. Ingold distinguishes *wayfaring*, the inhabitant's movement along a path that grows as it is walked, from *transport*, the carriage of goods between predetermined points, and the *meshwork* of entangled lifelines from the *network* of connected nodes. *Death Stranding*'s play is wayfaring; its plot is network-building, the linking of "Knot" cities into a chiral network. The tension between the two is the tension the sequel will make its subject: whether the network has captured the meshwork.

9.3 Chirality: The Hand of the World

The metaphysics of *Death Stranding* rests on "chiral matter," a substance associated with the Beach, the liminal realm of the dead, through which the chiral network

transmits data without delay. Chirality, as Chapter 2 recalled, is handedness, from the Greek *kheir*. The game's iconography is a gallery of hands: the handprints the invisible dead leave on the ground and on vehicles; the handshake, in a game whose protagonist suffers from haphephobia, the fear of being touched; the raised thumb of the "Like" that players award one another; the hand that holds an unborn child's pod against the chest.

The philosophical tradition of the hand is double. Heidegger, in *What Is Called Thinking?* (1951–52) and the *Parmenides* lectures (1942–43), treated the hand as essentially human, a singular organ belonging only to a being that speaks and thinks, and called thinking a handicraft. Derrida's "Geschlecht II: Heidegger's Hand" (1985) contested that singular hand – its humanism, its exclusion of the animal, its neglect of the plural hands that give and take – and *On Touching* (2000) traced the tradition's privileging of touch as the sense of immediate presence, arguing that to touch is always to touch a limit. *Death Stranding*'s hands are plural and chiral: left and right, living and dead, giving and receiving. Sam's haphephobia is Derrida's insight become pathology: touch exposes him to the limit of the other, and his gradual tolerance of touch is the arc of the game. Kant's incongruent counterparts return here in their original form. The living world and the Beach stand to each other as two hands do: corresponding in every element, opposed in orientation, joined only by reflection.

9.4 Ka, Ha, and the Umbilical Dead

The game's eschatology borrows from Egyptian anthropology, which articulated the person into several components, among them the *ka*, the vital double, and the *ba*, the mobile personality, alongside the physical body. *Death Stranding* pairs the *ka*, the soul, with the *ha*, the body, and makes their pathological tethering the cause of its catastrophe. At death the soul should pass through the Beach to the other side; if the corpse is not incinerated before necrosis sets in, the dead become stranded, returning as Beached Things – invisible to most of the living and bound by cords. Should a BT consume a living human, the result is a voidout, an annihilating explosion that leaves a crater.

The BT's cord is umbilical. At birth the cord is cut; in Kojima's death it is not, and the dead remain attached. Death in *Death Stranding* is a failed birth, and the work of the living is to complete the severance with care: to repatriate the dead to the dead. Among the game's earliest tasks is the transport of a corpse to an incinerator. This is *necro-logistics*, an economy of the dead administered as cargo. Mbembe's necropolitics (2003) named the sovereign's power to decide who must die. *Death Stranding*'s politics is its reverse: an administration not of death but of the dead, in which the duty of the living is custody.

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) identified the corpse as the utmost of abjection, death infecting life, and argued that the abject – what the body expels – marks and maintains the border of the self. *Death Stranding* weaponizes the abject with startling literalness. Sam's blood, sweat, urine, and excrement, collected in his private quarters, are made into grenades that repel the dead. The body's expulsions defend the boundary between the living and the stranded. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, and *Death Stranding*'s world is an elaborate logistics of matter out of place – cargo, corpses, excreta, crystals – in which every substance must be carried to where it belongs.

9.5 The Beach: Yomi and the Arithmetic of Births and Deaths

Every person in *Death Stranding* has a Beach, a personal shore between the living and the dead, littered with stranded whales and fish; the title invokes the mass strandings of cetaceans that remain, in part, unexplained. The Beach has a Japanese prototype. In the *Kojiki* (712), the god Izanagi descends to Yomi, the land of the dead, to bring back his wife Izanami. She asks him not to look upon her; he looks, and sees her body in decay. She pursues him, and he seals the passage between the worlds with a great boulder. Across it, Izanami vows to kill a thousand of his people each day; Izanagi answers that he will cause fifteen hundred to be born each day. The founding myth of Japanese mortality is an arithmetic of deaths and births, conducted across a wall between the living and the dead. *Death Stranding*'s dialectic of extinction and natality – an Extinction Entity on one side, an unborn child on the other – restages that exchange, and the Beach is the shore beneath the boulder.

The *Kojiki* also names the principle of the strand. Among the first deities to appear in its account of creation are Takamimusubi and Kamimusubi, whose names contain *musubi*: tying, binding, the generative union that brings things into being. Shinto practice marks sacred space with *shimenawa*, plaited ropes that at once enclose the sacred and bind it to the world – a rope that separates and connects, Weil's wall in straw. *Death Stranding*'s cities are called Knots. Shinkai Makoto's *Your Name* (2016) made *musubi* the theology of its braided cords, which tie two strangers across time, and East Asian legend gives the same figure as the red thread that binds those fated to meet. The strand has a Japanese metaphysics older than chirality: to tie is to create.

The Greek analogue is Orpheus, who loses Eurydice by looking back (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X); the biblical analogue is Lot's wife (Genesis 19:26). In each, the boundary between the living and the dead is a boundary of the gaze. *Death Stranding* converts this ancient prohibition into a mechanic, and in doing so reveals the deepest continuity in Kojima's design. In BT territory Sam must move slowly, scan for the invisible dead, and hold his breath to escape detection. This is stealth. The genre Kojima founded in 1987, in which the player hides from the liv-

ing, returns in 2019 as the practice of hiding from the dead. The stick's oldest technique survives inside the rope-game, reoriented toward the other world.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), filmed by Tarkovsky in 1972, supplies the speculative analogue: an ocean that returns the dead to the living as "visitors" composed from memory. The Beach is Lem's ocean made the common substrate of every human life – what Timothy Morton (2013) would call a hyperobject, massively distributed, viscous, inescapable.

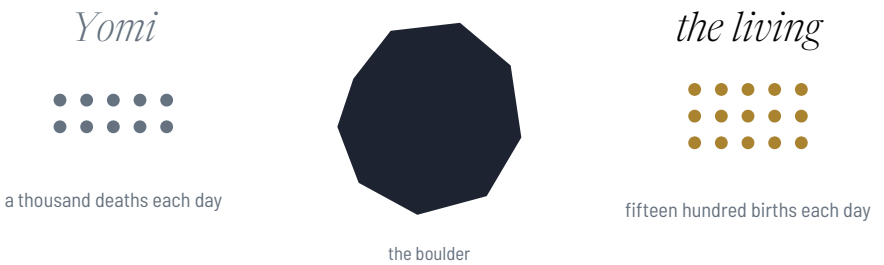


Figure 9.1 *The arithmetic at the boulder. Izanami's deaths and Izanagi's births, exchanged across the first wall between the living and the dead; each dot stands for a hundred.*

9.6 Timefall and the Mummy Complex

Death Stranding's rain, timefall, ages whatever it touches: it corrodes cargo containers, withers vegetation, and wrinkles skin. André Bazin's "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) located the origin of the plastic arts in a "mummy complex," the Egyptian practice of embalming the dead to preserve being against the flow of time, and argued that photography and cinema fulfil that impulse by embalming time itself. Kojima, the would-be filmmaker, built a world in which time assaults every object, and in which the porter's central labor is the preservation of cargo against decay. Timefall is anti-cinema: Bazin's embalming reversed into acceleration. The game is the medium in which preservation is not automatic, as in film, but must be performed, step by step, by a body under load.

Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that the realm of the dead is as extensive as the storage and transmission capacities of a culture. The chiral network literalizes Kittler: its capacity reaches into the realm of the dead because its medium is matter from the Beach. Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) argued that the archival drive cannot be separated from the death drive – that to archive is to preserve and destroy at once. The figure who presides over the network's extension, Amelie, is revealed as an Extinction Entity, the agent of the sixth mass extinction. The archivist of the living is the destroyer of the living. *Death Stranding* is a media theory: the network as a necromantic archive.

9.7 BB and Omelas

The game's most disturbing technology is the Bridge Baby: a fetus taken from a brain-dead mother, sustained in an artificial womb strapped to the porter's chest, linked to the Beach, and used to detect the invisible dead. Sam's BB, Lou, speaks through the controller itself. Her cries and heartbeat sound from its speaker, and her distress eases when the player rocks it. The program belongs to Bridges, the agency rebuilding the United Cities. The infrastructure that reconnects America depends on the instrumentalization of unborn children, whom Bridges decommissions when their usefulness ends.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city whose happiness depends on the misery of a single child kept in a cellar. Most citizens accept the bargain; a few walk away. *Death Stranding* is Omelas, and its protagonist chooses neither option. He does not stay, and he does not walk away; he carries the child out of the cellar. At the game's end, charged with incinerating Lou, Sam instead opens the pod and takes her out, and she lives. The Omelas child is not abandoned but taken up.

The choice is contested terrain in contemporary theory. Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) indicted "reproductive futurism," a politics conducted in the name of the Child at the expense of the living. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) urged instead that we make kin rather than babies, forming bonds of care that do not pass through biological reproduction. Within the first game Lou's origin is unknown, and she becomes Sam's kin by being carried; the sequel's disclosure of a blood tie, read in Chapter 10, complicates this without cancelling it. *Death Stranding* answers Edelman not with futurism but with Haraway: the Child is not begotten but borne. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) located in natality – the fact that new beings are born – the root of the human capacity to begin, and called it the miracle that saves the world. The game stakes its world on one such birth.

The figure has mythic and literary counterparts. Saint Christopher, the *Christophoros* or "Christ-bearer," carried a child across a river and found the child growing so heavy that he seemed to bear the world. Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) sends a father and son across a dead continent, "carrying the fire." Koike Kazuo and Kojima Gōseki's *Lone Wolf and Cub* (1970–76) follows a disgraced executioner who pushes his infant son in a cart through a hostile land – the Japanese prototype of the warrior become porter for a child. The shared surname of the manga's illustrator is an onomastic coincidence that this study declines to over-read.

9.8 Cliff's Wars

Through Lou's memories, Sam is drawn into the Beaches of a soldier, Cliff Unger, which take the form of the battlefields of the twentieth century – the trenches of the First World War, the Second World War, Vietnam – manned by skeletal soldiers. *Metal Gear* returns inside *Death Stranding* as purgatory: the century of the stick rendered as an underworld through which the porter must pass. Owen's "Strange Meeting," invoked in Chapter 3, describes this landscape exactly, and Nietzsche's eternal recurrence describes its temporality: the wars recur because they have not been mourned.

Cliff is revealed to have been searching for his own Bridge Baby, taken from him by Bridges' Bridge Baby program, and that child is revealed to be Sam. The soldier-father's pursuit, conducted through every war of the century, resolves at last into recognition and embrace. The *Metal Gear* father commanded, betrayed, and was killed by his son; the *Death Stranding* father fights his way through history to hold him. The pietà, in which a mother holds her dead son, is inverted: a dead father holds his living child. The stick's father has become a porter.

9.9 The Strand System: Mauss, Weil, Nancy, Esposito

Death Stranding's online architecture is asynchronous. Players never meet. Structures one player builds – bridges, ladders, ropes, roads, shelters, generators – appear in the worlds of others; cargo lost by one may be delivered by another; signs warn and encourage; and players award one another Likes, for which there is no negative counterpart.

Marcel Mauss's *Essay on the Gift* (1925) described the gift as a total social fact governed by three obligations – to give, to receive, and to reciprocate – and by the *hau*, the spirit of the gift that seeks to return to its origin. The Strand system is a gift economy that suspends the third obligation: Likes are given without debt, structures used without repayment. David Graeber's *Debt* (2011) called the everyday principle of "from each according to their abilities, to each according to their needs" baseline communism, operating beneath every economy. The Strand system makes baseline communism the visible infrastructure of a world.

Simone Weil supplies the image that best captures its form. In *Gravity and Grace* (1947), meditating on the Greek *metaxu*, the between, Weil described two prisoners in adjoining cells who communicate by knocking on the wall: the wall that separates them is also their means of communication, and every separation, she concluded, is a link. The Strand system is Weil's wall. Players are sealed in separate worlds, and their communication passes entirely through the separation, through objects left in one world that appear in another. Jean-Luc Nancy's *The Inoperative Community*

(1983; 1986) rejected the fantasy of community as fusion or common work, which he associated with totalitarianism, in favor of community as the exposure of singular beings to one another, an unworked being-in-common. Maurice Blanchot's *The Unavowable Community* (1983) described a community of those who have nothing in common. *Death Stranding*'s player-community is unworked and unavowable in exactly these senses: anonymous, unfused, exposed.

Roberto Esposito's *Communitas* (1998) and *Immunitas* (2002) derive community from *munus* – gift, obligation, office – so that the *communitas* is a group bound by a shared debt and immunity is exemption from the *munus*. Sam's haphephobia is *immunitas*, an exemption from contact. His cargo is *munus* in the most literal sense: a burden that is also a gift. His crossing of a continent is the passage from immunity to community, measured by his slowly growing capacity to bear touch.

The critical objections must be stated at full strength. The economy of Likes can be read as an aestheticization of the unpaid affective labor Tiziana Terranova (2000) analyzed in digital culture; the porter's solitary toil resembles the gig worker's; and Deborah Cowen's *The Deadly Life of Logistics* (2014) traced the military origins and violent operations of the supply chains the game appears to celebrate. Its release in November 2019, months before pandemic lockdowns made delivery workers "essential," sharpened both its resonance and the objection. And the shape of Sam's journey – westward from the Atlantic coast to the Pacific, to reconnect a shattered United States – retraces the route of Manifest Destiny. The game does not escape these readings. It does something more interesting: it stages them, by revealing that the network's architect is the agent of extinction and by placing at the center of reconnection an instrumentalized child whom the hero refuses to sacrifice. Its utopia carries its critique inside it, and its sequel will make the critique explicit.

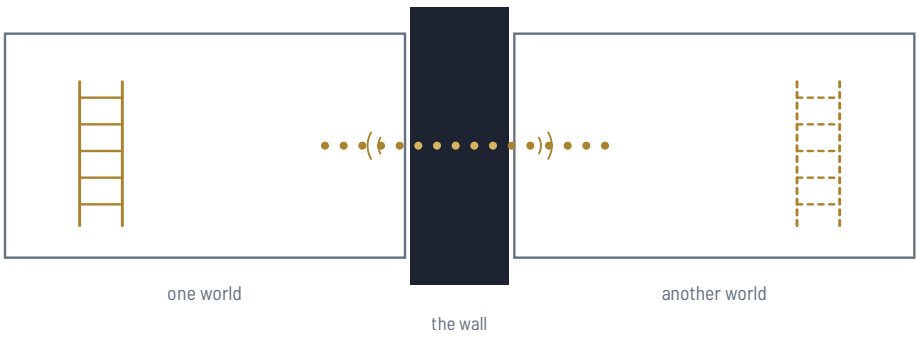


Figure 9.2 *The wall that communicates. Players never meet; what one builds appears in the other's world, carried through the separation itself.*

9.10 Amelie and the Last Stranding: Extinction and the Katechon

The history of life records five mass extinctions, from the end-Ordovician to the end-Cretaceous, and a growing consensus holds that human activity has initiated a sixth (Kolbert 2014). *Death Stranding*'s mythology attributes the five to Extinction Entities, beings whose existence portends the end of a dominant form of life, and reveals Amelie as the entity of the sixth. The antagonist Higgs, who longs for the end, is named for the Higgs boson, popularly called the "God particle" after Leon Lederman's book of 1993: the antagonist of a game about bearing weight is named for the origin of mass. His nihilism has philosophical analogues in Ray Brassier's *Nihil Unbound* (2007), for which extinction discloses that thought is, in a sense, already dead, and in Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011), a meditation on the world-without-us.

The resolution is not salvation. Sam persuades Amelie to delay the Last Stranding – not to abolish it. The end is deferred. This structure has a name in political theology. In the Second Epistle to the Thessalonians, Paul writes of a power that restrains the coming of lawlessness: "only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way" (2:7, King James Version). The restrainer, *to katechon*, became in Carl Schmitt's *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) the name for the political order – the Christian empire – that holds back the end; Massimo Cacciari (2013) and, critically, Giorgio Agamben (2000) have renewed the debate. *Death Stranding*'s ethic is katechontic, but its katechon is not an empire. It is a porter. The restrainer is not the sovereign who holds the world in place by force but the courier who holds it together by carrying: a katechon from below.

Walter Benjamin's "On the Concept of History" (1940) attributed to every generation a weak messianic power, to which the past has a claim. Kamo no Chōmei's *Hōjōki* (1212) opens with the image of a river whose flow never ceases while its water is never the same, the founding Japanese figure of impermanence. *Death Stranding* holds both thoughts: the world will end, and the claim of the dead and the unborn upon the living stands. Camus closed *The Myth of Sisyphus* by asking that Sisyphus be imagined happy, the struggle toward the heights enough to fill a human heart. Sam Porter Bridges is Sisyphus with a delivery order – and Abe's own *The Woman in the Dunes* (1962), in which a man trapped in a sandpit shovels sand without end until he no longer wishes to leave, is the Japanese Sisyphus who stands behind him. The porter's happiness is not the happiness of arrival. It is the happiness of the strand held taut.

10

Should We Have Connected?

Death Stranding 2 and the Autoimmunity of the Network

10.1 The Sequel as Auto-Critique

Death Stranding 2: On the Beach (2025) was marketed under two taglines, a question and a gesture: "Should we have connected?" and "Tomorrow is in your hands." The question obeys the law identified in Chapter 4. As *Sons of Liberty* interrogated the heroic myth of *Metal Gear Solid*, *On the Beach* interrogates the connective utopia of its predecessor. The gesture, as this chapter will show, is its answer.

The world eleven months after the averted Last Stranding is no better. Timefall persists, the Beached Things have evolved, and earthquakes, flash floods, and dust storms afflict the survivors. The organization that reconnected America has been dissolved, and deliveries across the United Cities are now made by automated robots operated by a new body, the Automated Public Assistance Company; Fragile has founded a company of her own, Drawbridge (GamingBolt). The porter's labor, which the first game made the substance of ethics, has been automated. Sam and Lou live off the grid in the south until Higgs attacks their refuge: Fragile escapes, mortally wounded though no one yet knows it, and Lou is apparently killed. A month later Sam joins Drawbridge aboard the DHV Magellan, a vessel that travels through tar, to pass through a "plate gate" – one of the openings that appeared after the failed Last Stranding and connect distant regions – and to link Australia to the chiral network.

10.2 Drawbridge: Simmel's Bridge and Door

Georg Simmel's essay "Bridge and Door" (1909) distinguishes two figures of human spatial will. The bridge connects what nature has separated, making the separation visible as overcome. The door both separates and connects, and its capacity to be closed gives it a meaning the bridge lacks: the human being, Simmel concludes, is the bordering creature who has no border, the one who can always step out into freedom. A drawbridge is the synthesis of Simmel's two figures: a bridge that can be raised, a connection endowed with the capacity to suspend itself. *Death Stranding* built bridges. *Death Stranding 2* is organized by a company that names itself after a bridge that has learned to be a door.

The synthesis is political. Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. Drawbridge's decision concerns connection itself: when to lower the span and when to raise it. The threshold, not the network, becomes the fundamental political category of the sequel, and the question "Should we have connected?" is reformulated as a question about who may decide, and how, when a connection is to be suspended.

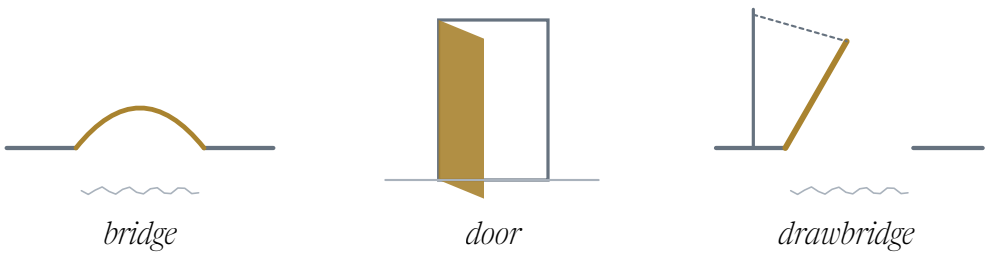


Figure 10.1 *Bridge, door, drawbridge: Simmel's two figures of spatial will, and the synthesis that names Fragile's company.*

10.3 Autoimmunity: The President Who Is a Crowd of the Dead

The sequel's hidden sovereign completes the corpus's history of the Dead Hand. The president of the Automated Public Assistance Company, who accompanies the expedition and urges the activation of plate gates across the world, is revealed to be no human being but a composite of the souls of those who died in a voidout, sustained through the company's automated system. He commands the skeletal "ghost mechs" that harry the crew, and his aim is that humanity should cease to venture out at all, avoiding every contact with the dead in order to survive (GamingBolt). He is ejected from the system by Die-Hardman, who has traveled concealed as the expedition's be-

nefactor, a crash-test dummy called Charlie – a body designed to absorb fatal impacts so that living bodies need not.

The president is *Peace Walker*'s Boss-intelligence turned inside out. There, a single dead mind installed in an automated weapon chose to drown itself rather than rule. Here, a crowd of the dead installed in an automated logistics system chooses to rule, and its program is total immunization: humanity sealed away from contact so that it may persist. Roberto Esposito's *Bíos* (2004) described modern politics as an immunitary paradigm that protects life by negating it, and whose limit is autoimmunity, the protective apparatus turning on the body it defends. Derrida's late work (1996; 2003) found the same structure in democracy, which must protect itself by means that threaten it. The sequel stages both horns of the autoimmune dilemma. Connection exposes the living to the dead – the network's medium is chiral matter from the Beach, and its expansion multiplies the points of contact through which catastrophe passes. But the refusal of connection is the regime of the dead themselves: isolation, administered by a corpse-collective through a machine. Neither the network nor its negation is innocent.

Hölderlin's "Patmos" (1803) supplied Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" with its closing hope: "Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch" – where danger is, the saving power also grows. Bernard Stiegler's pharmacology (2010) recast technics as pharmakon, at once poison and cure, requiring a therapeutics rather than a verdict. Byung-Chul Han's *In the Swarm* (2013) diagnosed the digital crowd as a swarm without a "we." *Death Stranding 2* accepts the pharmacological premise and refuses both of the verdicts it might seem to invite. The danger of the network does not justify its abolition, and its saving power does not justify its automation.

10.4 Magellan and the Antipodes

The vessel bears the name of the navigator whose expedition of 1519–22 first circumnavigated the globe – the inaugural event of planetary connection – and who was himself killed at Mactan in 1521 by the forces of Lapulapu, a local refusal of the connection he brought. The name encodes connection as conquest, and conquest as the thing connection can become.

Its destination sharpens the point. British colonization dispossessed Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples of their lands, frequently through frontier violence that included massacres, under a legal theory that denied there had been any owners to dispossess. Australia was claimed by Britain under the doctrine of *terra nullius*, the legal fiction of an empty land, which the High Court overturned only in *Mabo v Queensland (No 2)* (1992). A game whose mission is to "connect" a continent to an external network re-enacts, structurally, the incorporation of a land imagined as unconnected. Aboriginal songlines – the tracks of the Dreaming along which

country is sung into being and knowledge is carried across vast distances – constitute an Indigenous network ontology far older than any chiral network, and closer to Ingold's meshwork than to the network of nodes; Bruce Chatwin's *The Songlines* (1987) popularized the concept while romanticizing it, and the comparison must be made with that caution. It is offered here as a question the game poses to itself, not as a claim about its sources: what does it mean to connect a land that was never unconnected?

10.5 Dollman, Rainy, and the Inhabitants of the Between

The Magellan's crew is a gallery of metaxic beings. Dollman, a former spirit medium trapped in the body of a puppet, is the heir of *Snake Eater*'s The Sorrow, the medium as character, and of Heinrich von Kleist's "On the Marionette Theater" (1810), which argued that grace belongs either to the puppet that has no consciousness or to the god that has infinite consciousness, but not to the self-conscious human between them. In Japanese *bunraku* the puppeteers work in plain view, and Barthes's *Empire of Signs* (1970) made their visible labor an emblem of a theater that does not hide its means. Dollman is carried on Sam's hip and can be thrown to scout ahead: the puppet as strand-being, the soul moved by lines, and an image of the player's relation to the avatar.

Rainy is a pregnant woman who brings timefall wherever she goes, yet within a small radius around her a counter-rain, corefall, restores what it touches to youth. The image is Arendt's natality made meteorology. Where Bazin's mummy complex sought to embalm being against time, and timefall accelerated time against being, the pregnant body reverses time's damage locally: the unborn as a counter-entropy. The returning Deadman, who has crossed over to his Beach, fights for the living from beyond in a sword-wielding mech, until Higgs counterfeits him and seizes it. The dead who help and the dead who rule are, once again, indistinguishable at a glance.

10.6 Neil Vana and the Inversion of the Soldier

The sequel's central revelation concerns a soldier. Neil Vana, who first appears as an antagonist leading skeletal troops, was a smuggler for the United Cities who supplied women for the Bridge Baby experiments – a trafficker in stillmothers, the dark origin of the first game's necro-logistics, and a descendant of *Policenauts*' organ trade. He was also a childhood friend of Lucy, Sam's late wife. When Lucy, pregnant, discovered what the program intended for her daughter, she fled with Neil's help; Bridges killed them both and took the infant, and Bridget Strand, Sam's adoptive mother, told him that Lucy had taken her own life; and when Sam came to reclaim Lucy's body, Neil, returned as a Beached Thing, touched her corpse and triggered the

voidout that Sam had believed for years he caused (GamingBolt). The guilt that drove Sam into solitude was a misattribution.

On his Beach, Neil kept his identity. When Fragile carried the dying Lou there, she entrusted the child to him, and he protected her as she grew. The trafficker of unborn children became the guardian of one. In the terms Chapter 11 will formalize, Neil is the soldier inverted into a function of carrying: the dead soldier who keeps the child. His history also completes the series of weapons traced in Chapter 2. FOXDIE killed by genome, the parasite by idiom; the voidout that shaped Sam's life was death by contact, the touch of the dead upon the dead.

10.7 Tomorrow Is in Your Hands: Natality as Extinction

The young woman whom Sam finds on Neil's Beach, without memory, is named Tomorrow by the crew. She is revealed to be Lou – Louise, the daughter of Sam and Lucy, taken from her dead mother as the first Bridge Baby, BB-00, and grown to adulthood by the Beach's distortion of time. The Beached Thing of Lou that had appeared in Sam's pod after her apparent death was a hallucination Drawbridge produced to help him grieve. She is also a new Extinction Entity, and Higgs abducts her to trigger the Last Stranding. Sam confronts Higgs on the Beach in a duel fought with electric guitars; Lou, in the form of a giant infant, devours Higgs; Fragile, revealed to have been killed by Higgs at the very beginning, her soul having held off her body's death, passes away. Tomorrow embraces Sam and takes her name. In the closing images, Louise wears a porter's gear and stands before a new plate gate shaped as a pair of hands reaching toward each other (GamingBolt).

Five readings follow, each extending an argument made earlier.

The return of the gene. The first game's kinship by carrying is re-inscribed as kinship by blood: the Child was begotten after all. The sequel's auto-critique extends to its predecessor's Harawayan answer. But the gene returns transformed. Lou is not a copy of her father, as the clones were of theirs, but a counterpart: she has aged on another shore, lost her memory, borne another name, and must be recognized rather than identified. The gene comes back not as destiny but as recognition, and recognition is a relation between hands.

Natality as extinction. The child who is the future is also the end. Arendt's natality and Brassier's extinction coincide in one being, as Izanami's thousand deaths and Izanagi's fifteen hundred births coincide at the boulder. The katechon's task is therefore not to destroy the agent of extinction – that is Higgs's inverted wish – but to carry her: to raise the child who could end the world. The ethics of custody here meets its limit case, and does not flinch from it.

The therapeutic phantom. The hallucinated Beached Thing of Lou, administered so that Sam could mourn, is Ramachandran's mirror applied to grief: a fiction that animates what is lost so that pain may relax. *The Phantom Pain* made the phantom a

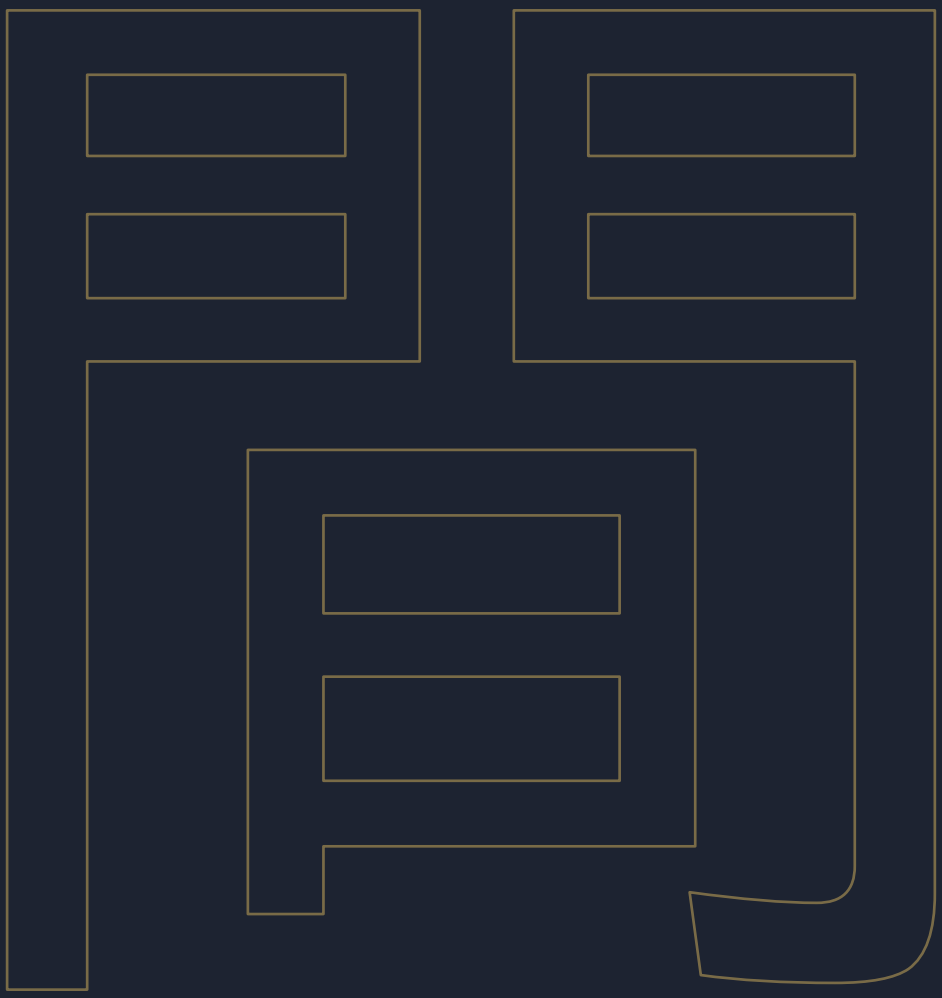
weapon of the state. *On the Beach* admits the phantom as a therapy among friends. The difference is not in the image but in the hand that offers it.

The bite. Lou devours the man who would end the world. If *Snake Eater* posed Nietzsche's riddle of the shepherd and the snake, the corpus's most recent answer gives the bite to an infant, and gives it comically, which is how Zarathustra said the transfigured shepherd laughed. And the final duel is fought with guitars – instruments of strings, used as clubs: the rope and the stick fused in a single object, and the fusion played for absurdity.

The gate of hands. The last image is a gate shaped as two hands reaching toward each other: incongruent counterparts made into a threshold. It is the emblem of this thesis, supplied by its object. Tomorrow is in your hands, plural, and the hands do not coincide.

10.8 An Answer to the Question

The diptych's answer to its own question can now be stated. Yes, we should have connected – but not totally, not automatically, and not without the drawbridge. The alternative to the network's autoimmunity is not the isolation prescribed by a sovereign of the dead, nor the extinction desired by a nihilist, nor the automation of delivery by machines. It is custody: connection held by living hands that can let go. The katechon of the first game, who delayed the end, matures in the second into a keeper of thresholds, who decides, case by case and by hand, what may pass.

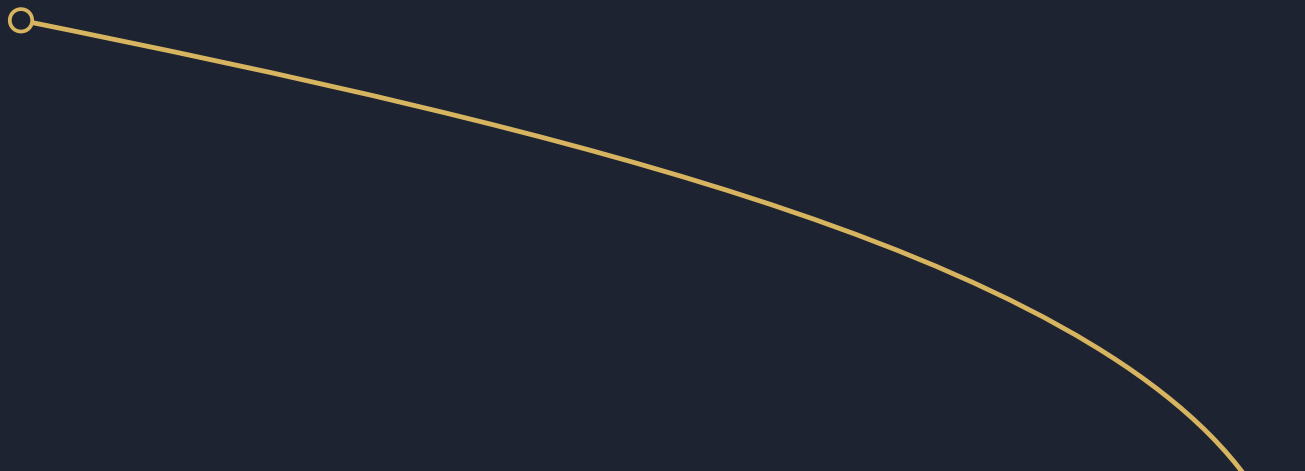


Part V

Synthesis

Mutually Assured Delivery

Part V constructs, from the readings of Parts I through IV, the theoretical instruments announced in the Introduction. Chapter 11 states the theory of chiral inheritance and the morphology of the line. Chapter 12 formalizes the passage from deterrence to delivery as a doctrine with its own failure modes. Chapter 13 proposes, on that basis, a theory of the videogame as a metaxic medium.



11

Incongruent Counterparts

A Theory of Chiral Inheritance

11.1 The Morphology of the Line

Lévi-Strauss closed "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) with a formula that he claimed governed every myth considered as the set of its variants:

$$F_x(a) : F_y(b) \simeq F_x(b) : F_{a^{-1}}(y)$$

A term a defined by a function x stands to a term b defined by a function y as the term b defined by the function x stands to a function formed from the inversion of a, applied to y. The final member is asymmetrical — a term becomes a function and is inverted — and that twist, Lévi-Strauss held, is the signature of mythic transformation. The formula is notoriously obscure, and Jean Petitot's morphodynamic reading (1988) remains the most rigorous attempt to give it determinate content. Applied with care, it fits the corpus with uncanny precision.

Let a be the soldier and b the porter; let x be the function of severing (killing, cutting, deterring) and y the function of carrying (bearing, connecting, delivering). Then:

$$F_{\text{sever}}(\text{soldier}) : F_{\text{carry}}(\text{porter})$$
$$\simeq F_{\text{sever}}(\text{porter}) : F_{\text{soldier}^{-1}}(\text{carry})$$

The soldier's severing is to the porter's carrying as the porter's severing is to a carrying performed by the soldier inverted. The third term is the stick inside the rope-game: the porter's binding cord, his grenades of blood, above all his incineration of corpses — the cut that completes death, without which the dead cannot depart. The fourth term is the decisive one. The inverse of the soldier is the dead, disarmed, or repatriated soldier, and he appears in the corpus exactly where the formula predicts, as a function of carrying. *Peace Walker*'s Boss-intelligence, a dead soldier's mind, carries the weapon into the lake. Cliff Unger, a dead soldier, carries his son through the wars of the century. Neil Vana, a dead soldier, keeps the child on his Beach. Big Boss, dying, sits beside his son at the grave. The critics who saw a conversion from soldier to porter saw the second ratio and missed the fourth. The soldier does not simply become the porter. The soldier, inverted by death, becomes carrying itself.

The material morpheme of this transformation group is the line. It appears as *serpent* (the Snakes, the ouroboros); as *cord* (the surrogacy of Les Enfants Terribles, the Bridge Baby's link to the Beach, the tether of the stranded dead); as *rope* (Abe's *nawa*, the Strand); as *cable* (the Patriots' network, the SOP, the chiral network); and as *noose* (the loop of *P.T.*, the narrowing corridor). Its topologies are three. The line *severed* is the stick: the cut, the red line of deterrence, the incinerator. The line *closed* is the ouroboros: revenge, simulation, recursion, the self-perpetuating system. The line *extended* is the strand: the bridge, the delivery, the cord held without tethering. The ethical topology of the corpus is the open curve — the line that reaches without closing and without breaking.

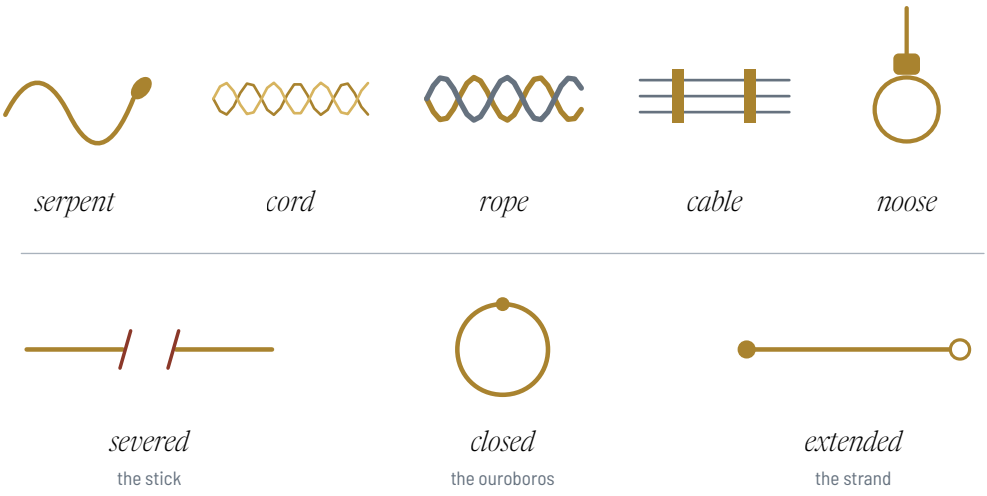


Figure 11.1 *The morphology of the line: five forms of one figure, and its three topologies.*

11.2 Six Regimes of Transmission

The readings of Parts I through IV can be arrayed as six regimes of transmission. Each is defined by what passes from one generation or body to another, by the weapon that selects its victims, by the coincidence it attempts to force, and by the chiral resolution the corpus proposes.

Gene *Metal Gear Solid (1998); Snatcher (1988)*

What passes
Genome

Weapon and criterion
FOXDIE: kills by genetic identity

Forced coincidence
The clone as the father's copy

Chiral resolution
Snake chooses whom to live for; the gene's verdict reduced to mortality

Meme *Sons of Liberty (2001)*

What passes
Role, information

Weapon and criterion
The S3 Plan: selects what may be known

Forced coincidence
Raiden trained to be Snake

Chiral resolution
The discarded dog tags; transmission chosen, not imposed

Scene *Snake Eater (2004); Peace Walker (2010)*

What passes
Loyalty, will

Weapon and criterion
The automated deterrent: kills without hesitation

Forced coincidence
Disciples executing The Boss's will as unity

Chiral resolution
The Boss-intelligence drowns itself; her will reread as releasement

Sense *Guns of the Patriots (2008)*

What passes
Affect, code, authorization

Weapon and criterion
The SOP and ID-locked arms: kill by authorization

Forced coincidence
Governance by the founders' effigies

Chiral resolution
Zero's death; the earth returned to usufruct

Word *Ground Zeroes (2014); The Phantom Pain (2015)*

What passes
Language, face, legend

Weapon and criterion
The vocal cord parasite: kills by idiom

Forced coincidence
Venom made Big Boss

Chiral resolution
Translation; Quiet's silence; the mirror broken

Strand *Death Stranding (2019); On the Beach (2025)*

What passes
Cargo, the dead, the unborn

Weapon and criterion
The voidout: kills by contact; the network: by connection

Forced coincidence
Total connection; total isolation

Chiral resolution
Repatriation; the drawbridge; Louise recognized

Figure 11.2 *Six regimes of transmission, knotted along the line of the corpus. Each forces an inheritance into coincidence and releases it into correspondence.*

Read downward, the table is a history of the criterion of death, moving from what one is to what one knows, wills, feels, says, and touches. Read across, each row repeats a single drama: an inheritance forced into coincidence, and released into correspondence.

11.3 The Law of Non-Coincidence

The table yields a law. Inheritance succeeds when the heir is the counterpart of the ancestor and fails when the heir is made to be its copy. Three failure modes recur. *Coincidence* forces the heir onto the ancestor's boundaries: the clone, the simulated Snake, the phantom Big Boss, the governance of the living by the dead. *Severance* refuses inheritance altogether: Skull Face's extermination of a language, Higgs's longing for extinction, the dead president's sealing of the living away from contact. *Closure* loops inheritance back upon itself: revenge, which repeats the injury; the corridor that returns; the system that perpetuates its founders. Against all three, the corpus's resolutions share a structure. Snake chooses whom to live for; Raiden discards the tags; Big Boss releases the world and dies beside his son; Sam carries the child out of the cellar and, years later, recognizes the daughter who no longer remembers him. In each case a relation is maintained across a difference that is not abolished. That is chirality: correspondence without superposition.

Two mirrors condense the law. Lacan's mirror (1949) captures: the infant identifies with an image that is alien to it, and the ego is born in that alienation. Ramachandran's mirror frees: the patient uses the reflection of what remains to relieve the pain of what is gone. The glass is the same; the difference lies in whether the reflection is taken for identity or used as counterpart. *The Phantom Pain* shows the first; *On the Beach*, in its hallucinated Lou, shows the second. The juridical form of the law is Jefferson's usufruct: the heir uses and enjoys what the dead left without being governed by it. Its procedural form is the Fulton balloon: the enemy carried off the battlefield, neither killed nor copied, but transformed into a comrade who remains himself.

11.4 The Two Metaxic Beings

Every major work in the corpus turns on one or both of two beings who dwell between existence and its absence: the unborn and the dead. Les Enfants Terribles begins with embryos and ends with a demand for a father's corpse. *Peace Walker* installs a dead mind in a weapon; *Ground Zeroes* returns a girl with a bomb inside her body. *P.T.* sets a fetus in a sink beneath a ghost. *Death Stranding* binds an unborn child to the porter's chest and fills the world with the stranded dead; *On the Beach* reveals that the child who is the future is also an agent of the end, and that the sovereign of the network is a crowd of the dead.

The *Kojiki*'s arithmetic of a thousand deaths and fifteen hundred births is the mythic form of this preoccupation; its philosophical form is the opposition between Heidegger, for whom the human is defined by being-toward-death (1927), and Arendt, for whom it is defined by natality (1958). Kojima's corpus refuses to choose. Its subject is defined neither by its birth nor by its death alone, but by its custody of the unborn and the dead – a being between births and deaths, charged with both.

Plato gave this being its oldest name. In the *Symposium*, Diotima describes Eros as a daimon, neither mortal nor immortal, who interprets and conveys messages between gods and men; in Jowett's translation, he is "the mediator who spans the chasm which divides them" (202e–203a). His parents are Poros – resource, way, passage – and Penia, poverty and need, and his condition is his mother's: he "has no shoes, nor a house to dwell in," and sleeps on the bare earth under the open sky (203c–d). The description is uncannily exact. Kojima's porter is the child of the way and of need: his boots wear through, his feet blister and bleed, he sleeps in shelters or in the open, and his office is to carry what passes between worlds. Sam Porter Bridges is Diotima's daimon in a timefall-proof suit.

11.5 Watsuji's *Aidagara* and the Japanese Between

The Japanese philosophical tradition supplies the third and most systematic account of the between. Watsuji Tetsurō, in the ethics he developed from 1934 and published as *Rinrigaku* (1937–49), observed that the Japanese word for the human being, *ningen*, is written with the characters for person and between, and argued that the human is constituted not as an isolated individual but in *aidagara*, betweenness: ethics is the study of the relations in which persons exist. His *Fūdo* (1935), written in response to *Being and Time*, charged Heidegger with privileging individual temporality over the social spatiality of climate and land, through which human beings understand themselves together. *Death Stranding* is a *fūdo* game. Its climate – timefall, snow, flood, the rivers

that must be forded – is not scenery but the medium through which relations are formed and tested.

The aesthetic concept of *ma*, the interval in space and time, which Isozaki Arata's exhibition *Ma: Space-Time in Japan* (Paris, 1978) presented to Western audiences, names the formal correlate. Stealth is an art of *ma*: the wait between patrols, the silence before movement. *Death Stranding*'s empty landscapes between deliveries are *ma* at the scale of a continent; Quiet's silence is *ma* in speech. Nishida Kitarō's "Basho" (1926) conceived the place in which beings are located without being reduced to one another, culminating in a place of absolute nothingness. The Beach is a *basho*: the field in which the living and the dead stand together without becoming each other.

Three traditions of the between – Plato's *metaxy*, Weil's *metaxu*, Watsuji's *aidagara* and the aesthetics of *ma* – converge in the corpus. This thesis names their convergence *metaxic*, and claims it as an elective affinity rather than a genealogy. What the corpus adds to the three is a medium in which they can be practiced rather than contemplated. Chapter 13 describes that medium; Chapter 12 first describes the politics it makes possible.

A fourth tradition stands beside the three. Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) located the reality of relation neither in the I nor in the Thou but in the between, and his later essay on the interhuman named *das Zwischenmenschliche* as the sphere in which persons meet without being merged. Buber's between is dialogical, a meeting in speech. Kojima's is asynchronous, a meeting through objects left for strangers. The difference marks the corpus's contribution to the tradition: a between that holds even where no word can pass.

12

From Mutually Assured Destruction to Mutually Assured Delivery

12.1 The Doctrine of Destruction

In the 1960s the United States Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara articulated the doctrine of "assured destruction": the capacity to inflict unacceptable damage upon an aggressor even after absorbing a first strike. Once the Soviet Union achieved comparable capacity, assurance became mutual, and the strategist Donald Brennan is generally credited with condensing the condition into an acronym meant as mockery: MAD. The doctrine can be reduced to four structural features.

The first is *interdependence by hostage*. Each side's population is held hostage by the other's arsenal, so that security becomes a function of the adversary's vulnerability. The second is *credibility by automatism*. The threat must be believed, which is why theorists from Kahn onward, and the engineers of the Soviet Perimeter system after them, sought to remove hesitation from retaliation – to make the response independent of any living will. The dead hand is deterrence's logical guarantor, not its aberration. The third is *stability by symmetry*. Neither side can escape vulnerability, and stability is the balance of terrors. The fourth is its *telos*: peace as the indefinite postponement of the end – the perpetual peace of Kant's inn sign, above a churchyard.

12.2 The Forward Operating Base as Ludic Deterrence

The Phantom Pain's Forward Operating Bases implement each feature in play, as Chapter 7 described. Players are interdependent by invasion: each base is exposed to the others. Nuclear weapons reward their holders and discourage attack. Populations are unequal, and the strong prey upon the weak. The hidden ending requires a collective act – the dismantling of every weapon on a platform – that the incentives of the system make nearly impossible, and the history of that ending reproduces the history of the nuclear age in miniature: disarmament attained only where the world had shrunk, contested on arrival, and reversed within a day. The FOB system is not a satire of deterrence. It is a working model of it, and its verdict is empirical.

12.3 The Strand as Ludic Delivery

Death Stranding's Strand system transposes each of deterrence's four features into its chiral counterpart.

Interdependence by burden replaces interdependence by hostage. Each player's world is built in part by others: a road one travels is another's labor, a ladder at a cliff another's foresight. Survival depends on the carrying of others, not on their fear. *Credibility by care* replaces credibility by automatism. A bond in the Strand system is believed because its traces are visible – the bridge that holds, the shelter in the storm, the Like received – and because those traces must be maintained. Structures decay under timefall unless players contribute materials to repair them, so that upkeep becomes a shared practice. Mierle Laderman Ukeles's "Manifesto for Maintenance Art 1969!" asked who, after the revolution, would take out the garbage, and declared the labor of maintenance an art. The Strand system makes maintenance its guarantor. *Stability by asymmetric generosity* replaces stability by symmetry: no reciprocity is required, Likes are given freely, and the system runs on what Graeber called baseline communism. Its *telos*, finally, is not the peace of the grave but the deferral of the end: the katechon of Chapter 9.

Game theory clarifies what the design achieves. Robert Axelrod's *The Evolution of Cooperation* (1984) showed that in an iterated prisoner's dilemma, reciprocal strategies such as tit-for-tat can sustain cooperation among self-interested agents; one of his central historical cases was the live-and-let-live system of the First World War trenches, where enemies learned restraint through tacit signals (Chapter 1). *Death Stranding* goes further: it removes defection from the space of possible actions, since no player can damage another's world. Lawrence Lessig's *Code and Other Laws of Cyberspace* (1999) argued that the architecture of a system regulates behavior as surely as law does. The Strand system enforces cooperation by architecture

rather than by norm. This is its achievement and its limit, for a cooperation that cannot fail is not, in the full sense, chosen. The sequel's drawbridge restores the choice.

Mutually Assured Destruction		*Mutually Assured Delivery*
Each side holds the other's population hostage	Interdependence	Each player depends on infrastructure built by others
Automatism of retaliation; the dead hand	Credibility	Visible, maintained traces of care; the living hand
Symmetrical vulnerability	Stability	Asymmetrical generosity without required reciprocity
A response that fires without hesitation	Guarantor	Upkeep against decay by many hands
Forward Operating Bases, *The Phantom Pain* (2015)	Ludic instance	Strand system, *Death Stranding* (2019)
Launch; extinction	Failure mode	Autoimmunity; the network as vector; automation
Perpetual peace of the churchyard	Telos	Deferral of the end by restraint from below

Figure 12.1 *Two doctrines as incongruent counterparts: one structure, mirrored across the axis of the feature they share.*

12.4 The Autoimmune Turn

The two doctrines are chiral counterparts. They share a structure – total interdependence, a guarantor, a telos of the postponed end – and differ in handedness: threat against burden, dead hand against living hand, churchyard against deferral. Like enantiomers, they can convert into each other, and *Death Stranding 2* shows the conversion. The network that delivers also transmits catastrophe; the voidout is a nuclear event inside the network, an annihilation leaving a crater where a living body met a dead one; and the sovereign of the expanded network proves to be a crowd of the dead administering an automated system and prescribing isolation. Delivery does not abolish deterrence's danger. It inverts the danger's valence while preserving its structure, and therefore preserves its failure modes in mirror form. The automation of delivery is the return of the dead hand.

12.5 The Katechontic Settlement

The diptych's resolution can be stated as a doctrine in four principles. This is Mutually Assured Delivery in its mature form.

1. **Revocability.** Every connection must be suspendable by living judgment. This is the principle of the drawbridge, and it answers the autoimmunity of total connection.
2. **Non-automation of custody.** The guarantor of a connection must be a living hand, not a system that acts without hesitation on behalf of the absent. This answers the dead president, as *Peace Walker*'s drowned machine had answered Coldman.
3. **Maintenance before expansion.** The ethic of repair precedes the ethic of extension. The worldwide activation of gates, urged by the dead president, is refused in favor of what can be kept.
4. **Deferral, not salvation.** The end is held back, not abolished. The porter is a katechon from below, possessed of what Benjamin called a weak messianic power and oriented toward what Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) called the Not-Yet.

12.6 Objections and Replies

First, the romance of logistics. The doctrine may be accused of aestheticizing the labor of delivery that Deborah Cowen (2014) traced to military origins and Guy Standing (2011) placed at the center of a precarious class, and of dignifying the unpaid affective labor Terranova (2000) analyzed. The reply is partial. The sequel automates delivery and makes automation the instrument of its antagonist; the first game indicts its own logistics state as a trafficker in unborn children. The corpus's ethic is not logistics but custody, and the difference lies in what is carried: a commodity or a charge. Kojima's porters carry charges – the dead, the unborn, the fragile. The objection nevertheless identifies a real ambivalence, which the games stage rather than resolve.

Second, the imperial shape of reconnection. The westward crossing of the first game retraces Manifest Destiny; the second names its ship for Magellan and sails it to a continent once declared empty. The reply is that the corpus stages its own imperial genealogy – Mount Rushmore in the Patriots, the Navajo code talkers in *The Phantom Pain*, Magellan's death at Mactan in the name of the vessel. But the objection stands in part. The games rarely give voice to those whose lands their networks cross, and an immanent critique is not a restitution.

Third, reproductive futurism. Edelman's indictment of politics conducted in the name of the Child applies to the first game's ending. The sequel complicates it decisively by making the child an agent of extinction. The future is not redemptive but dangerous, and custody of it is custody of the end.

Fourth, the gamification of care. Han and Jagoda (2020) have criticized the translation of social life into game mechanics as a technique of neoliberal governance. The Like in the Strand system cannot be exchanged or accumulated as currency, but it does feed systems of progression. The objection must be conceded in part: the doctrine is enacted in a commercial product whose incentives it cannot fully escape.

Fifth, authorial mortmain. The possessory credit "A Hideo Kojima Game" can be read as a dead hand laid over the work of hundreds of collaborators, a legend worn like Big Boss's face. The corpus anticipates the objection in *The Phantom Pain*, and its author has supplied a reply of his own: Kojima has said he has a pitch for a third *Death Stranding* but does not wish to be the one to make it (GamingBolt). A world handed to successors is a world held in usufruct, and the gesture is the doctrine applied by its author to himself.

13

The Metaxic Medium

Toward a Kojimean Ludology

13.1 Metalepsis as Contact

Kojima's reputation for breaking the fourth wall rests on a catalogue that has become folklore. Psycho Mantis reads the player's memory card, commands the controller to move, and can be defeated only when the player changes ports. The Colonel orders Raiden to turn off the console; a counterfeit screen announces a "Fission Mailed"; the protagonist's dog tags bear the player's name. The End dies if the player's calendar advances a week. *Boktai* requires real sunlight. *Snake Eater* ends the game with a "Time Paradox" if the player kills a character whose survival the later chronology requires. *Death Stranding* gives its porter a private room in which he acknowledges the camera, and gives its unborn child a voice that speaks from the controller.

Genette's term for such transgressions of narrative level is metalepsis (1972; 2004), and the received reading treats Kojima's metalepses as postmodern irony, devices for exposing the fiction as fiction in the manner of Brecht's alienation effect. That reading is not wrong, but it is incomplete. What distinguishes Kojima's metalepses is that so many of them are *haptic*. They do not merely address the player; they touch the player's world – his memory card, his calendar, his sunlight, his hands. The screen in Kojima is less a frame than a membrane: semi-permeable, traversed in both directions, a surface through which the game reaches the player's world and the player's world reaches the game. Metalepsis in this corpus is not a figure of irony but a figure of contact.

13.2 The Two Hands

The player holds the controller in two hands; the avatar has two hands; and the mapping between them is chiral. In *Death Stranding*, holding the left and right triggers makes Sam grip the left and right straps of his load to steady himself: the player's two fingers correspond to the porter's two hands, functionally identical and spatially non-superposable, on either side of the screen. Brendan Keogh's *A Play of Bodies* (2018) described videogame play as an embodied circuit of eyes, ears, hands, screen, and avatar. Kojima makes that circuit a theme, from the vibration through which Psycho Mantis claims the player's hands in 1998 to the microwave corridor of 2008, where repeated pressing becomes a labor of compassion, to the infant whose distress the player soothes by rocking the controller in 2019. *Boktai*'s subtitle announced the program in 2003: *The Sun Is in Your Hand*. The tagline of 2025 completes it: *Tomorrow is in your hands*.

Kant's incongruent counterparts are the formal relation between player and avatar. The avatar is the player's mirror hand: corresponding in every operation, opposed in orientation, separated by a surface that cannot be crossed by superposition but only by reflection and touch. This is the chiral structure of Chapter 11 realized in the medium itself, and it explains why Kojima's thematic doubles – Solid and Liquid, Big Boss and Venom, Sam and Lou – feel inseparable from his formal experiments. The medium is a chiral pair, and the corpus is its meditation on itself.

13.3 Ergodic Literalism

Espen Aarseth (1997) coined the term *ergodic*, from the Greek *ergon*, work, and *hodos*, path, for texts that require non-trivial effort to traverse. *Death Stranding* literalizes the etymology: its play is work along paths. Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) argued that failure is central to what games mean, the source of their peculiar mixture of pain and pleasure. *Death Stranding*'s characteristic failure is the stumble – the porter losing balance, the cargo scattering down a slope – and its meaning is care: the fall is a lapse of attention to weight. Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) classified play into *agôn*, *alea*, *mimicry*, and *ilinx*, the last the pursuit of vertigo. *Death Stranding*'s *ilinx* is the vertigo of balance under load, and its *mimicry* is the imitation of labor itself. The so-called walking simulator is, on this account, the most rigorously ergodic of genres.

13.4 The Magic Circle as Beach: An Ethics of the Respawn

Huizinga located play within a magic circle set apart from ordinary life. Arnold van Gennep's *The Rites of Passage* (1909) described the threshold phase of every passage

between states, and Victor Turner's *The Ritual Process* (1969) developed it as liminality, the condition of being betwixt and between. The Beach is a limen, and the game is a Beach: the zone where the player passes into another state and back.

The corpus's most persistent formal inquiry concerns what happens at the edge of that zone when the avatar dies. Kojima has interrogated the game over for a quarter-century. The Sorrow's river ends in a counterfeit death escaped by a pill that feigns death; *Snake Eater*'s "Time Paradox" makes a killing that violates the saga's causality into a death of the game itself; *Sons of Liberty* parodies the game-over screen; The End dies of duration; Venom's horn records the residue of play in the avatar's flesh. *Death Stranding* gives the problem its definitive form. Sam is a Repatriate: when he dies, he returns from the Seam between worlds. But a death that comes when the dead consume him produces a voidout, and its crater remains in the world. The respawn, in every other game a consequence-free resurrection, here inscribes the world. Kojima's corpus thereby develops a medium-specific eschatology. The game over becomes a theological problem: what returns, what remains, and who bears the cost.

13.5 Custody as Aesthetic

Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) distinguished two archaic types of the narrator – the resident who knows the local tradition and the traveler who returns from afar with tales – and argued that death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell: the storyteller borrows his authority from death. The porter is Benjamin's traveler, and *Death Stranding* literalizes the sanction, deriving every one of its stories from the Beach. Le Guin's carrier bag supplies the work's form: the game as a vessel that holds the player's hours, acts, and losses in relation. Kojima's games are, quite literally, archives of their players: a memory card read aloud, a procession of the killed, a world bearing the structures and Likes of strangers.

The metaxic medium can now be defined by three properties. *Its material is the between*: the interval between player and avatar, between player and player, between the living and the dead. *Its form is the wall that communicates*: Weil's prison wall, realized as asynchronous play, haptic metalepsis, and the chiral mapping of hands. *Its ethic is custody*: the work holds what passes through it – the player's time, the memory of the dead, the future of the unborn – and asks the player to hold them in turn.

The definition corrects the oldest charge against its author. Kojima is not a maker of "cinematic games" frustrated by a lesser medium. Cinema, in Bazin's account, embalms: it preserves time by fixing it. Kojima's games carry: they preserve by bearing, step by step, under load, against the rain that ages everything. The difference between his medium and the one he professes to love is the difference between the frame and the hand.

Keeping the Line Open

This thesis has argued that the ludic corpus of Hideo Kojima, from *Metal Gear* (1987) to *Death Stranding 2: On the Beach* (2025), is a single myth-system organized by the figure of the line, and that its successive works explore the line's three topologies – severed, closed, extended – across six regimes of transmission. From those readings it has constructed three instruments. *Chiral inheritance* names the law by which every inheritance in the corpus succeeds as counterpart and fails as copy. *The Dead Hand* names the single antagonist the corpus pursues across nuclear, juridical, political, economic, and metaphysical registers: the rule of the dead over the living. *Mutually Assured Delivery* names the counter-doctrine the corpus develops against deterrence – preserving its insight into interdependence, inverting its valence from threat to burden, discovering in the sequel its autoimmune vulnerability, and maturing into a settlement of revocable, non-automated, maintenance-first connection that defers rather than abolishes the end. The instruments converge in a theory of the videogame as a *metaxic medium*, whose material is the between, whose form is the wall that communicates, and whose ethic is the custody of the unborn and the dead.

Contributions

The argument contributes to five fields. To **Kojima studies** it offers an account of the corpus as one transformation group, a correction of the conversion narrative, a reconstruction of its genealogy from Dawkins, Cocteau, Abe, Huizinga, Morin, Melville, Kahn, and Schelling, and an extension of that genealogy through elective affinities with Le Guin, Weil, Watsuji, Kant, and Simmel. It identifies several structures not previously remarked: the clone names as a metallurgical phase diagram of modernity; the Patriots' intelligences as a digital Mount Rushmore; the Patriots' forbidden name spelled in the kana row that marks the Japanese-English border of *l* and *r*; the return of stealth in *Death Stranding* as concealment from the dead; and the Lévi-Straussian inversion by which the dead soldier becomes a function of carrying.

To **game studies** it offers a method for reading multiplayer architectures as political doctrines, demonstrated in the contrast between *The Phantom Pain*'s Forward Operating Bases and *Death Stranding*'s Strand system; an account of metalepsis as haptic contact rather than irony; an ethics of the respawn; and the concept of the metaxic medium. To **political theory and the philosophy of technology** it offers the Dead Hand as a unified concept running from mortmain to Perimeter to automated logistics, the drawbridge principle as a contribution to debates on the autoimmunity of networks, and the figure of a katechon from below. To the **nuclear humanities and Japanese studies** it offers a reading of the corpus as postwar Japanese nuclear criticism – REX as Godzilla's descendant, the Emmerich lineage as a house of Atreus whose crime is fission, Japan's Article 9 and Costa Rica's abolished army facing each other across the Pacific as incongruent counterparts. To **comparative philosophy** it offers a transcultural philosophy of the between – Plato's *metaxy*, Weil's *metaxu*, Watsuji's *aidagara*, the aesthetics of *ma* – tested in a popular medium where it can be practiced rather than merely contemplated.

Limitations

The study has relied principally on English localizations and English-language scholarship, and the Japanese-language paratexts of the corpus remain underused. It has reduced a collaborative practice to an author-function, leaving the contributions of designers, writers, actors, and composers under-described. It has courted what may be called the Lévi-Straussian temptation: a structure seen in retrospect looks inevitable, and the readings may impose a coherence the works possess only in part. Its elective affinities cannot be verified, only judged fruitful or idle. Its account of the most recent work draws in part on published summaries of plot, and its readings of *On the Beach* should be considered provisional. Above all, the corpus is open.

Horizon

Two works stand at that opening. *OD*, a horror anthology co-written with Jordan Peele for Xbox, remains in production without a release date; it returns Kojima to the domestic uncanny of *P.T.*, and will test whether the metaxic medium can hold fear as it has held grief. *Physint*, an espionage project whose publishing support PlayStation Studios withdrew in June 2026 and which Xbox took up in September, is projected for release beyond 2030 (GamingBolt). It promises the return of the stick four decades after Kojima joined Konami in 1986, and if the corpus's law of the second installment holds, it will be an auto-critique of the rope. A third *Death Stranding* exists, so far, as a pitch its author has said he would rather someone else realize (GamingBolt) – a world offered to other hands. Future research should pursue reception and community studies of the corpus's collective events – the disarma-

ment of a dwindling platform, the crowd-solved corridor of *P.T.*, the millions of anonymous gifts of the Strand – as well as its Japanese-language archives and its migration into other media.

Coda

In 1987 a soldier crawled through a fortress unseen, sent by a father who meant him to die. In 2025 a daughter in porter's gear stands before a gate shaped as two hands reaching toward each other. A single line runs between those images. It has been cut, and it has closed upon itself, and it has not broken. Abe's stick holds harm at a distance; his rope draws the good near. What the corpus teaches is that both are held by the same hand, and that the hand must decide, each time, which it is holding. To keep the line open – neither severed nor closed – is the ethic of Kojima's work and the conclusion of this thesis.

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katechon
autoimmunity
communitas and *immunitas*
biopolitics
necropolitics
necro-logistics
societies of control
simulacra
meme
the selfish gene
cloning
mimetic rivalry
ressentiment
hauntology
phantom limb
mourning and melancholia
cryptonymy
ouroboros
linguistic relativity
carrier bag theory
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